

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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1 Samuel 1:1

- Elkanah was a Levite (a member of the tribe of Levi) ([1 Chronicles 6:22–27](#)). After the Israelites conquered the promised land, the Levites received towns in other tribes' territories, including Ephraim ([Joshua 21:20](#)).
- Elkanah's hometown was Ramah ([1 Samuel 2:11](#)). Do not confuse this Ramah with the one in the land of Benjamin (see [Joshua 18:25](#); [Judges 19:13](#); [Matthew 2:18](#)).
- The region of Zuph got its name from one of Elkanah's ancestors, a Levite from the Kohath clan ([1 Chronicles 6:35](#)). Saul first met Samuel in Zuph while looking for his father's donkeys ([1 Samuel 9:5](#)).
- Elkanah's long family history suggests he was important in society.

1 Samuel 1:2

In the Bible, when a man married two wives at the same time, it often led to serious conflict ([1 Samuel 1:6–7](#); [Genesis 16](#); [21](#); [29](#)).

1 Samuel 1:3

- Elkanah made this trip every year because the law required people to attend three festivals a year ([Exodus 23:14–17](#)).
- According to God's law, Israelites had to sacrifice at God's chosen sanctuary ([Deuteronomy 12:1–28](#)). From the time of Joshua to Samuel, God's sanctuary, the tabernacle, was in Shiloh ([Joshua 18:1](#)). Shiloh was a town in Ephraim about 13.7 kilometers (8.5 miles) north of Bethel on the way to Shechem. King David later moved the tabernacle to Jerusalem ([2 Samuel 6](#)).
- *the LORD of Hosts*: In the Hebrew Old Testament, God is often called *Yahweh Tseba'oth* or *'Elohim Tseba'oth*. These titles are traditionally translated as “Lord of hosts” and “God of hosts.”

The term “hosts” (Hebrew *tseba'oth*, traditionally “sabaoth”) usually means “armies.” It can refer to human armies, like the armies of Israel (for example, [1 Samuel 17:45](#)). I can also refer to foreign armies sent to carry out the Lord's plans (for example, [Isaiah 9:11–13](#)). However, it most often refers to God's armies of angels sent from heaven to carry out his commands and fight on earth (for example, [2 Kings 6:17](#)).

This title highlights God's role as a powerful warrior in the story involving the ark of the covenant and the Philistines ([1 Samuel 4–6](#)).

1 Samuel 1:4

Sacrifice ... portions [of the meat]: Some sacrifices included sharing part of the animal in a community meal (see [Leviticus 7:11–34](#)).

1 Samuel 1:7

the house of the LORD: This is another name for the tabernacle. It is also known as "the temple of the LORD" in [1 Samuel 1:9](#). These names show that the tabernacle, a portable building, was the main sanctuary in Shiloh.

1 Samuel 1:9

the temple of the LORD: This means the Lord's sanctuary. Solomon's Temple was not built yet, so *temple* here refers to the Lord's holy place.

1 Samuel 1:11

Hannah promised to dedicate her child to the Lord as a Nazirite (see [Numbers 6:1-21](#)). She might have hoped her child would be like Samson, a deliverer of God's people (compare [Judges 13](#)). A deliverer was someone who rescued the Israelites from their enemies

1 Samuel 1:13-14

Some people may have used the feast times at Shiloh to drink too much alcohol instead of worshipping. Eli wrongly thought Hannah was just another person who was drunk (see [Acts 2:13-15](#)).

1 Samuel 1:16

wicked woman (Hebrew *a daughter of Belial*): This phrase describes a worthless person. Belial means "worthlessness" and people later used it as a name for Satan ([2 Corinthians 6:15](#)). In Hebrew, a *son of* or *daughter of* a quality refers to someone who shows that quality strongly.

1 Samuel 1:17-18

A blessing was more than just wishful thinking. It was often God's way of giving a real benefit (see, for example, [Genesis 27:1-40](#); [28:1-4](#); [32:22-32](#); [48:1-49:28](#)). Because this blessing from God's high priest assured Hannah that her prayer would be answered, she was no longer sad.

1 Samuel 1:22

After the boy is weaned: Hannah likely nursed Samuel for two to four years.

1 Samuel 1:23

Elkanah could have canceled Hannah's promise (see [Numbers 30:12-14](#)). But he chose to affirm and support it instead.

1 Samuel 2:1

my horn is exalted: Literally *has lifted my horn*; see also [1 Samuel 2:10](#). The horn of a strong animal, like an ox or bull, was a symbol of strength. It was raised in victory after defeating an enemy (see also [1 Kings 22:11](#)).

1 Samuel 2:1-10

Hannah's Prayer of Praise celebrates Samuel's dedication to serving God. It highlights God's:

- Uniqueness ([1 Samuel 2:1-2](#))
- Power to change fortunes ([1 Samuel 2:3-9](#))
- Ability to strengthen his chosen king ([1 Samuel 2:10](#))

Like Mary's Song of Praise in [Luke 1:46-55](#), Hannah's prayer emphasizes God bringing down the rich and powerful and lifting up the poor and oppressed ([1 Samuel 2:7-8](#); [Luke 1:52-53](#)). David's prayer in [2 Samuel 22](#) is another beautiful statement of God's saving power for his chosen king ([1 Samuel 2:10](#)). God will bring down the rich, unrighteous rulers (like Eli, Saul, or Herod). Leaders who follow God's will like Samuel, David or Jesus will be lifted up to a higher position or status.

1 Samuel 2:2

- *no one besides You*: David reacted the same way after hearing God's promises about his kingship ([2 Samuel 7:22](#)).
- *Rock* (compare [2 Samuel 22:2-3, 32](#)): God offers stability and security to those who trust in him.

1 Samuel 2:3

Do not boast so proudly, or let arrogance...: Peninnah showed this attitude (see [1 Samuel 1:6-7](#)). In contrast, Hannah was humbly dependent on God. This means she did not think too highly of herself. Instead, she trusted in God and relied on him for help.

1 Samuel 2:4-8

Hannah celebrated God's power to completely change people's situations.

1 Samuel 2:5

- Those who were hungry now have enough to eat (see [1 Samuel 1:7, 18](#)).
- The phrase *seven children* poetically means that a woman without children would be blessed with a home full of children (see [1 Samuel 2:21](#)).

1 Samuel 2:7-8

Compare with [Psalm 113:7-9](#).

1 Samuel 2:8

The entire earth belongs to the Lord. God, who created and rules everything, can:

- change circumstances ([1 Samuel 2:4-8](#)),
- protect those who are faithful ([1 Samuel 2:9](#)),
- judge those who are wicked, and
- give strength to his chosen king ([1 Samuel 2:10](#)).

1 Samuel 2:10

- The king was to use his God-given power to help the oppressed, the hungry, and those unable to have children (see [Psalm 72:14, 12-14](#); [Proverbs 31:8-9](#)).
- *He will exalt the horn*: See study note on 1 Samuel 2:1.
- *His anointed* (Hebrew *mashiakh*): This part of Hannah's prayer predicts both Israel's anointed kings and God's ultimate Anointed King—the Messiah, Jesus Christ (see [1 Samuel 12:3-5](#); [24:6, 10](#); [Psalm 132:17](#); [Daniel 9:25-26](#)).

1 Samuel 2:12

- *wicked men* (Hebrew *sons of Belial*): See study note on 1:16.
- *had no regard for* (literally *did not know*) *the LORD*: Even though they were priests among God's people, they ignored God and did not follow his will (compare [Jeremiah 2:8](#)).

1 Samuel 2:13-17

The priests were meant to take their share of the meat only after it was boiled (see [Numbers 6:19](#)). Eli's sons ignored God's rules ([1 Samuel 2:13-14, 17](#)).

1 Samuel 2:15

God's law stated that the fat from a sacrificial animal belonged to the Lord. The priests had to burn the fat on the altar before anything else could be done with the animal ([Leviticus 3:3-17](#)).

1 Samuel 2:18

- The phrase *Samuel served the Lord* refers to the religious duties of Levites and priests (see, for example, [Numbers 3:4](#); [8:19, 24](#); [Deuteronomy 18:7](#)). Samuel, like Eli's sons, was a Levite (see study note on 1 Samuel 1:1). However, unlike Eli's sons, Samuel performed his duties well.
- He wore a linen garment similar to what priests wore when serving in the sanctuary (see study note on 1 Samuel 22:18).

1 Samuel 2:20

Eli would bless: Blessing was one of the functions of a priest ([Numbers 6:23-27](#); [Deuteronomy 10:8](#); [1 Chronicles 23:13](#)). See study note on 1 Samuel 1:17-18.

1 Samuel 2:22

- *sleeping with the women*: Eli's sons were likely influenced by Canaanite religious practices, which included sex as part of the ceremony.
- *who served at the entrance*: See [Exodus 38:8](#).

1 Samuel 2:22-25

Eli's weak efforts to correct his the behavior of his sons (see [1 Samuel 2:29](#)) show he raised them without discipline ([1 Samuel 3:13](#)).

1 Samuel 2:25

- *God (or the judges; Hebrew 'elohim)*: The Hebrew word translated *intercede* is plural here. When 'elohim means "God" it often takes a singular verb. Some ancient translations interpret 'elohim as "judges" in this context. If so, the judges would mediate for the guilty in a human court. Yet, many Hebrew scholars argue that 'elohim should not be translated as "judges." If so, how could God *intercede* for the man who sinned? Eli might have believed that court decisions came directly from God. God might work through his written laws or through other events to either free or find guilty a person accused of doing something wrong. Or Eli might have been talking about the system of animal sacrifices.
- The sexual wrongdoing in ([1 Samuel 2:22](#)) and excessive eating in ([1 Samuel 2:12-17](#)) of Eli's sons were sins against the Lord. This was because they were corrupting how Israel worshiped God. No one can speak to God on behalf of sinners who completely refuse to follow God's will (see [Matthew 12:31](#)).
- Eli's sons ignored their father because the Lord had already started to punish them by making their hearts stubborn (see [Exodus 4:21](#); [7:3](#); [8:15-32](#); [10:27](#); [11:10](#)).

1 Samuel 2:26

As children, both Samuel and Jesus had extraordinary qualities ([1 Samuel 2:21](#); see also [Luke 2:40, 52](#)). Samuel was one of Jesus' forerunners (someone who came before and prepared the way). Samuel showed what would happen to Jesus through his words, actions, and sometimes through events in his own life that were similar to what would happen in Jesus' life.

1 Samuel 2:27

"Man of God" is another name for a prophet ([1 Samuel 9:6](#); [1 Kings 13:1](#); [2 Kings 1:9](#)).

1 Samuel 2:29

Eli did not stop his sons from doing wrong, showing disrespect for God's sacrifices and offerings. Eli gained from their actions, so God blamed him for allowing it.

1 Samuel 2:30

that your house and the house of your father would walk before Me forever: See [Exodus 29:9](#) and [Numbers 25:13](#). God will honor another of Aaron's descendants (see study note on 1 Samuel 2:35) and reject Eli's family, removing them from the priesthood ([1 Samuel 2:31-35](#)).

1 Samuel 2:32-33

reach old age: In the Old Testament, a short life often shows God's disapproval. A long life shows God's blessing (see [Genesis 15:15](#); [1 Kings 3:14](#); [Psalm 91:16](#)).

1 Samuel 2:35

a faithful priest: Zadok and his family later took over the priesthood from Eli's family ([1 Kings 2:26-27](#), [35](#)).

1 Samuel 3:1

the word of the LORD was rare, and visions were scarce: God was not revealing his will through prophets or priests. This means that God was not regularly speaking to his people or giving them guidance.

However, this time of spiritual darkness was about to end when God began to communicate with Samuel ([1 Samuel 3:2-4:1a](#)).

1 Samuel 3:2

Eli was almost blind, both physically and spiritually ([3:1](#)).

1 Samuel 3:3

The priests were responsible for keeping the lamp of God burning through the night ([Exod 27:20-21](#); [30:7-8](#)). • That Samuel was sleeping . . . near the Ark symbolizes his nearness to God's presence and purpose, in contrast to Eli and his sons.

1 Samuel 3:7

Samuel did not yet know the Lord: He lacked direct experience of the Lord. In contrast, Eli's sons did not know the Lord (see study note on 2:12) in that they were morally and spiritually deficient.

1 Samuel 3:8

Eli realized: Despite his many shortcomings, Eli was not completely without spiritual insight.

1 Samuel 3:10

The doubling of the name calls attention to the seriousness of the moment (cp. [Gen 22:11](#); [Exod 3:4](#); [Matt 27:46](#); [Luke 22:31](#); [Acts 9:4](#)). • Samuel omits "Lord" (see [1 Sam 3:9](#)) from his response either out of reverence for the name or because of a lingering uncertainty about who was speaking.

1 Samuel 3:11

The phrase a shocking thing conveys the magnitude and severity of God's judgment. God's actions would also be of national significance for Israel (cp. [2 Kgs 21:12](#); [Jer 19:3](#)).

1 Samuel 3:12

my threats: See [2:27-36](#).

1 Samuel 3:13

his sons are blaspheming God: They were expressing contempt for God through their actions.

- hasn't disciplined them: Eli rebuked his sons ([2:23-25](#)), but he did not restrain them.

1 Samuel 3:14

Neither blood sacrifices nor offerings would be acceptable on behalf of Eli and his sons. The offerings of [Lev 4-5](#) were for sins committed inadvertently or unintentionally, whereas the sins of Eli and his sons were deliberate and rebellious.

1 Samuel 3:15

Samuel was afraid to tell Eli of God's plans for him and his family either because he respected Eli's position or he feared for his own safety.

1 Samuel 3:19

proved to be reliable: Samuel was an authentic prophet ([3:20](#); see [Deut 18:21-22](#)).

1 Samuel 3:20

The whole nation, from Dan in the north to Beersheba in the south, acknowledged that Samuel was God's prophet. • confirmed as a prophet: The reliability of Samuel's message ([3:19](#)) made it evident that God was speaking through him.

1 Samuel 3:21-4.1

The Lord continued to appear: God reopened the lines of communication with Israel through Samuel (cp. [3:1](#)). • Shiloh: See study note on 1:3.

1 Samuel 4:1

the Philistines: See "The Philistines" Profile. • The exact location of Ebenezer is unknown. It was probably just east of Aphek (see also [1 Sam 7:12](#) and corresponding study note). • Aphek was west of Shiloh, well inland and well north of Philistine

territory. By camping there, the Philistines might have been trying to seize more Israelite territory.

1 Samuel 4:1-7.2

The crisis surrounding the Ark of the Covenant demonstrated Israel's need for Samuel's leadership and fulfilled prophecies about Eli and his sons ([3:11-14](#)).

1 Samuel 4:3

The Israelites were often defeated in war because of the sin of one individual or the entire nation ([Josh 7](#)). In this defeat, no one inquired whether sin was the cause; apparently no one had even asked the Lord whether they should engage the Philistines in the first place (cp. [1 Chr 14:13-16](#)). Instead, the Israelites treated the Ark, the most sacred symbol of the Lord's presence, as a charm to ward off misfortune. Carrying the Ark into battle was not necessarily wrong (cp. [Josh 6:2-21](#)), but neither would this act ensure God's blessing and victory.

1 Samuel 4:4

Lord of Heaven's Armies: See study note on 1:3. • enthroned between the cherubim: A representation of God's glorious presence hovered over the Ark in the Most Holy Place (God's "throne room"). • The involvement of Eli's sons, Hophni and Phinehas, foreshadows the disaster that ensued (see [3:11-14](#)).

1 Samuel 4:6-7

Like the Israelites, the Philistines regarded the Ark as a powerful talisman (see [4:2-3](#)) and believed that its presence in battle would mean sure disaster for them.

1 Samuel 4:8

the same gods who destroyed the Egyptians: The Philistines, who worshiped many gods, knew of the Lord's power. Yet they knew nothing of his nature as the one true God. • destroyed . . . with plagues:

The Lord later showed his power against the Philistines similarly (see [5:6-6:6](#)).

1 Samuel 4:10

30,000 was more than seven times as many as haddied previously without the Ark ([4:2](#)). The Israelites learned the hard way that the Ark was not a talisman to ward off misfortune.

1 Samuel 4:11

That the Ark . . . was captured was devastating to the Israelites ([4:12-22](#)). • The deaths of Hophni and Phinehas fulfilled the Lord's word to Eli ([2:34](#)). Although they are the only casualties named, they were not the only Israelites who had sinned (see [7:3-6](#)).

1 Samuel 4:12

had torn his clothes and put dust on his head: This description indicates grief and loss (e.g., [Josh 7:6](#); [2 Sam 1:2](#); [15:32](#); [Job 2:12](#)).

1 Samuel 4:15

blind: See [3:2](#) and corresponding study note.

1 Samuel 4:18

Eli fell backward: Either he was startled or he had a heart attack when he heard the message. Eli's fatal fall symbolizes his family's fall from the priesthood and the end of the abomination that his sons began ([2:12-17](#)). • Israel's judge: Priesthood and judgeship were not incompatible (cp. [Exod 18:13-26](#); [Deut 17:8-13](#)). Samuel replaced Eli as Israel's judge and provided leadership that Eli had failed to provide (see [1 Sam 7:12-17](#)). • The phrase for forty years incorporates Eli's career into the conceptual and temporal framework of the book of Judges (cp. [Judg 3:11](#); [5:31](#); [8:28](#); [13:1](#)).

1 Samuel 4:20-21

The name Ichabod contains the Hebrew word kabod (glory; see [Exod 24:15-17](#)). A similar word is used to describe Eli in [1 Sam 4:18](#) (Hebrew kabed, "heavy"). The disappearance of the Ark parallels the demise of Eli's house. Although the Israelites experienced a stunning loss of divine glory and protection (cp. [Ezek 8-10](#); [Luke 19:41-44](#); [21:20-24](#)), God's glorious presence would subsequently return to his people ([1 Sam 6:1-21](#); cp. [Ezek 43:1-8](#)).

1 Samuel 5:1

Ebenezer: See study note on 4:1b. • Ashdod, one of the five important Philistine cities (see [6:17](#)), was located along the same major trade highway (the Great Trunk Road) as Aphek.

1 Samuel 5:2

Dagon was one of the Philistines' gods (see [Judg 16:23-24](#)). The name could be related to the Hebrew dag ("fish"), an appropriate name for a god of seafaring people. More likely, it reflects the Hebrew dagan ("grain"), suggesting a fertility or agriculture god.

1 Samuel 5:4

his head and hands had broken off: A symbol of God's supremacy over the idol ([5:7](#); see also [17:51](#)).

1 Samuel 5:5

step on its threshold: While the Philistines might have believed that Dagon's amputations resulted from their failure to honor the god properly, the true failure was in worshiping an idol rather than honoring the one true God ([Isa 44:6-20](#)).

1 Samuel 5:6

tumors: The Hebrew term can mean simply "swellings." A possible alternative translation is "hemorrhoids." They were possibly the fatal *buboes* of bubonic plague, which attack the lower body,

especially the rectal area. Rats are known carriers of the plague.

1 Samuel 5:8

rulers (or *overlords*): Each of the five major Philistine cities had its own ruler ([6:16-18](#)). • Move it: Despite the obvious danger, the Philistines relished their captured trophy enough to relocate it rather than return it. • Gath, one of the five major Philistine cities, was nearby.

1 Samuel 5:9

God often used great panic to incapacitate and overwhelm Israel's enemies ([14:15](#), [20](#); [Deut 7:23](#); [Ezek 22:5](#); [Amos 3:9](#)).

1 Samuel 5:10

Ekron, another of the five major Philistine cities (see [6:17](#)), was just five miles north of Gath.

1 Samuel 6:2

priests and diviners: Divination was a part of Philistine religion (cp. [28:7](#); [Deut 18:10-14](#)).

1 Samuel 6:3

It is unlikely the Philistines were aware of Israelite worship regulations. A Philistine guilt offering would have been a payment to the deity in an attempt to avert his wrath (contrast the notion of atonement from [Lev 16](#)).

1 Samuel 6:4

rats: See study note on 5:6.

1 Samuel 6:6

The Philistines had thought they could overcome the Lord by fighting harder ([4:9](#)). They had defeated the Israelites, but they now realized that they could not defeat Israel's God.

1 Samuel 6:7

shut their calves away: If the cows went against their maternal nature and left their calves to take the Ark to Israel, it would prove that the plague was from Israel's God ([6:9](#)).

1 Samuel 6:9

Beth-shemesh was the closest Israelite town to Ekron ([5:10](#)).

1 Samuel 6:13

Harvesting wheat was usually done in May or June.

1 Samuel 6:14

This burnt offering could have been for forgiveness of sin (see [7:9-10](#); [Lev 1:3-17](#)), but it was more likely a freewill expression of love or thanksgiving (see [Lev 22:18-22](#)).

1 Samuel 6:15

Providentially, the Ark had arrived in Beth-shemesh ([6:13](#)), which was a Levite city ([Josh 21:13-16](#)). The men of the tribe of Levi who lived there could safely move the Ark (see [Num 4:15](#)).

1 Samuel 6:17

guilt offering: See study note on 6:3. • Ashdod, Gaza, Ashkelon, Gath, and Ekron: These five major Philistine cities were located on or near the Great Trunk Road. This major ancient trade route connected Egypt with Mesopotamia via the coastal plain of Canaan. Each city was governed by a king-like ruler ([6:16](#)).

1 Samuel 6:19

seventy men: Beth-shemesh was a small village. • because they looked into the Ark: Physical contact with the Ark was prohibited ([Num 4:15](#); [2 Sam 6:6-](#)

8), as was looking inside it ([Num 4:20](#)). Those who were killed lacked reverence for God's holiness.

1 Samuel 6:20

Who is able to stand? Even God's people were not immune to his wrath when his holiness was violated. • Where can we send the Ark? When faced with God's holiness, the Israelites echoed the distress of the pagan Philistines ([6:2](#)).

1 Samuel 6:21

Kiriath-jearim was nearby, about ten miles northeast of Beth-shemesh.

1 Samuel 7:1

The men of Kiriath-jearim who transported the Ark and Eleazar were probably Levites (see [6:15](#); [Num 1:47-51](#)). • in charge of it: The same verb describes the Levites' duty of guarding the Tabernacle ([Num 1:53](#); [3:7](#)).

1 Samuel 7:2

Twenty years covers the time until Samuel assembled the people at Mizpah ([7:5-6](#)). David later brought the Ark to Jerusalem ([2 Sam 6:1-19](#)).

1 Samuel 7:3

People cannot expect God's blessing unless they get rid of what is contrary to his will (see [Gen 35:2](#); [Josh 24:14](#)). • Ashtoreth was the Canaanite goddess of fertility associated with Baal ([1 Sam 7:4](#)). Worship of Canaanite deities was an ongoing problem throughout Israel's history. The people started worshipping idols during the twenty-year period mentioned in [7:2](#), or perhaps they had done so ever since the days of the judges ([8:8](#); [Judg 6:25](#); cp. [Amos 5:25-26](#)). Israel's devastating defeat by the Philistines was due not only to the sins of Eli's two sons but to several generations of unfaithfulness to God.

1 Samuel 7:3-10

The change in the people's standing with God, not the presence of the Ark (see [4:3-11](#)), led Israel to victory against the Philistines.

1 Samuel 7:5

Mizpah was an administrative center and rallying point for the nation (see [7:16](#); [10:17](#); [Judg 20:1](#)). • I will pray . . . for you: Eli's question in [1 Sam 2:25](#) is answered here; Samuel was the intercessor Israel needed.

1 Samuel 7:6

drew water . . . poured it out: This type of ceremony is not mentioned elsewhere in the Old Testament. • At times Israelites went without food to express grief or to seek the Lord's favor ([2 Sam 1:12](#); [12:22-23](#); [1 Kgs 21:27](#); [Ezra 8:21-23](#); [Neh 9:1](#); [Esth 4:3, 16](#); [Joel 2:12](#); cp. [Luke 2:37](#); [Acts 13:2-3](#); [14:23](#)). • To have Samuel as Israel's judge was refreshing compared to Eli's failed leadership (see [1 Sam 4:18](#) and corresponding study note) and the leadership of some other judges (e.g., Gideon, [Judg 8:22-27](#); Jephthah, [Judg 11:30-12:7](#); and Samson, [Judg 13:1-16:21](#)).

1 Samuel 7:9

The whole burnt offering was probably for forgiveness of sin (see [Lev 1:1-4](#)). • The Lord answered with a forceful thunderclap ([1 Sam 7:10](#)).

1 Samuel 7:10

voice of thunder: See [2:10](#). God often used similar tactics to throw Israel's enemies into confusion and defeat them (e.g., [Exod 14:24](#); [23:27](#); [Josh 10:10](#); [Judg 4:15](#)).

1 Samuel 7:12

Ebenezer: The location of this stone memorial is unknown. The Philistines had defeated Israel and captured the Ark at a place with the same name ([4:1](#); [5:1](#)). Samuel erected this memorial to

commemorate God's help in turning the tide against the Philistine attacks.

1 Samuel 7:13

The Philistines were quiet for some time—until Saul became king (see [13:5](#)). • God's powerful hand, not Samuel's giftedness, was the key factor in Israel's deliverance from the Philistines.

1 Samuel 7:14

The Amorites had inhabited Canaan and the region east of the Jordan before Israel's conquest of the Promised Land (see [Gen 15:16](#); [Deut 3:8](#); [Josh 2:10](#)). Some Amorites remained in the area after the conquest (see [2 Sam 21:2](#)).

1 Samuel 7:15

judge for the rest of his life: Once Saul became king (ch [10](#)), Samuel's role was more judicial than military.

1 Samuel 7:16

Bethel and Mizpah were places of national assembly in the judges era ([Judg 20:1, 18, 26; 21:1–2](#)). Bethel's significance went back to the days of Abraham ([Gen 12:8; 13:3–4; 28:10–22; 35:1–15](#)). • Gilgal, located near Jericho, had been a sacred place since Joshua's day ([Josh 4:19–24; 5:2–10](#)). From this circuit, Samuel influenced “all the people of Israel” ([1 Sam 10:17](#)).

1 Samuel 7:17

Ramah was Samuel's hometown (see [1:1](#)).

1 Samuel 8:1–12.25

During Israel's transition to a monarchy, neither God ([8:7–9](#)) nor Samuel ([12:1–25](#)) was pleased by the people's demand for a king. Saul, the first king (chs [9–11](#)), failed in his role (chs [13–31](#)) and fulfilled Samuel's warnings (see [8:10–18](#); cp. [16:1–13](#)).

1 Samuel 8:2

Samuel's two oldest sons functioned as judges in Beersheba, fifty miles south of their father's home.

1 Samuel 8:3

they were not like their father: They were more like Eli's two sons ([2:12–17](#)). Their corruption was a primary reason the era of the judges ended.

1 Samuel 8:5

you are now old, and your sons are not like you: Judges tended to be local leaders; kings, as national leaders, were more capable of uniting a whole nation in times of crisis ([8:20](#)). However, a spiritual problem underlay the request for a king ([8:7–8](#)). • Other nations, such as Egypt and Sumer, had monarchies for almost 2,000 years before Samuel's time.

1 Samuel 8:6

Samuel was displeased: He probably felt personally rejected ([8:7](#)).

1 Samuel 8:7

Do everything they say: God rarely instructed a prophet to heed the voice of the errant populace. The will of the people and the will of God would converge in King David (see [2 Sam 7:8–17](#)). • they are rejecting me: Their rejection of judgeship was a deeper rejection of God's rule and sovereignty (see also [1 Sam 12:1–17](#)).

1 Samuel 8:8

followed other gods: The people's request for a king was tantamount to idolatry. Israel's monarchy was a divine concession rather than a divine gift. Kingship or any other human institution becomes idolatrous when it replaces trust in God.

1 Samuel 8:10–18

These verses list the disadvantages of kingship. Each sentence begins with something the king would take. A king would be a confiscator, not just a protector.

1 Samuel 8:11

While the people wanted a king to *judge* them, Samuel warned that the king would reign over them. They wanted a leader but received a ruler.

1 Samuel 8:12–17

The king would take people as well as possessions.

1 Samuel 8:15

A tenth of the harvest was already required as a sacred donation to support God's Temple and servants ([Deut 12:6, 17–18; 14:22–29; 26:12–15](#)). The king would demand an additional tenth, a burdensome amount given the uncertainties of agriculture.

1 Samuel 8:17

you will be his slaves: By demanding a king, the people whose ancestors had once been slaves in Egypt were risking a new enslavement (cp. [1 Kgs 12:1–20](#)).

1 Samuel 8:18

The people would beg for relief as their ancestors had done in Egypt under another punishing and exacting ruler (see [Exod 3:7](#)).

1 Samuel 8:20

God had set Israel apart from the nations ([Lev 20:26; Num 23:9](#)). By insisting on a king and desiring to be like the nations, they were rejecting God's plan (see [1 Sam 8:5–7](#); cp. [Deut 17:14](#)). • judge us and lead us into battle: Kings performed three basic functions: (1) waging offensive and

defensive war, (2) administering law, and (3) ensuring economic well-being.

1 Samuel 8:21

repeated to the Lord: The role of a prophet included bringing the people's case before God (cp. [Num 27:5](#)).

1 Samuel 8:22

give them a king: See study note on 8:7; cp. [Rom 1:24–26](#).

1 Samuel 9:1

influential man named Kish: Saul came from a wealthy family.

1 Samuel 9:1–11.15

Saul's rise to power involved a threefold sequence: (1) his secret anointing by Samuel ([9:1–10:16](#)), (2) his selection by lot ([10:17–27](#)), and (3) his victory over the Ammonites ([11:1–15](#)). See also study note on 13:1–16:13.

1 Samuel 9:2

Saul's mere appearance—most handsome . . . taller than anyone else—inspired loyalty among the people (see [10:23](#); cp. [16:12; 2 Sam 14:25–26](#)).

1 Samuel 9:5

Zuph, which was probably located in Ephraim, was Samuel's home region ([1:1](#)). God's providence led Saul there.

1 Samuel 9:6

The phrase man of God was used to describe a prophet ([2:27](#); also [Deut 33:1; Josh 14:6; 1 Kgs 13:1–32](#)).

1 Samuel 9:7

anything to offer him: Evidently, it was customary to take a gift when one sought the help of a prophet (cp. [1 Kgs 14:2-3](#); [2 Kgs 5:5, 15](#); [8:8](#)). Some false prophets demanded gifts in return for their services ([Mic 3:11](#)). Saul's concern might reflect the spiritual ignorance of thinking that advice from a prophet of God could be purchased ([Acts 8:20](#)).

1 Samuel 9:12

Leaders of a community would normally convene for business at the town gates (cp. [Ruth 4:1-2](#)). • take part in a public sacrifice: Samuel is one of very few individuals in whom prophetic and priestly ministries unite (also Moses, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and Jesus). • place of worship (literally *high place*): An open-air altar or platform on a hill near the city gate. High places easily became sites for pagan idolatry (see [Num 33:52](#); [1 Kgs 15:14](#); [22:43](#); [2 Kgs 12:3](#); [14:4](#); [15:4](#), [35](#)).

1 Samuel 9:13

to eat: Part of a sacrifice made during worship was burned on the altar, while the remainder was eaten in a ceremonial feast by the guests (see also [1:4](#)). • to bless the food: As a Levite, Samuel's priestly role included offering blessings (see [Deut 10:8](#); [21:5](#)).

1 Samuel 9:16

God's directive to anoint him (by pouring olive oil on the head) marked Saul's elevation in status and consecration for a special purpose (see [Exod 30:22-33](#); [Lev 8:12](#); [1 Kgs 19:16](#); [Isa 45:1](#)). • He will rescue them: As they had requested ([1 Sam 8:20](#); cp. [Judg 13:5](#)). David eventually subdued the Philistines ([2 Sam 5:17-25](#); [8:1](#); [21:15](#), [18-22](#)). • for I have . . . heard their cry (cp. [Exod 3:7-9](#)): The Philistines were again threatening to conquer Israel and demand homage from them as vassals.

1 Samuel 9:21

the smallest tribe: Saul tried to downplay Benjamin's prominence, but they were powerful warriors ([Judg 20:14-31](#); cp. study note on 1 Sam

10:17). What better tribe to lead in battle? • least important of all the families: Cp. [9:1](#).

1 Samuel 9:25

A typical house had a flat roof that was used for a variety of purposes, such as sleeping in warm weather (see [Deut 22:8](#); [2 Kgs 4:10](#)).

1 Samuel 10:1

Samuel later repeated this process by anointing David with olive oil ([16:13](#)). • The people of Israel did not belong to the king but to the Lord. The king was to act as manager rather than owner (cp. [8:10-18](#)).

1 Samuel 10:2

Rachel's tomb at Zelzah: See [Gen 35:16-20](#); the precise location is unknown.

1 Samuel 10:2-6

These three "signs" were to convince a reluctant Saul ([9:21](#)) that he had in fact been chosen to be king.

1 Samuel 10:3

oak of Tabor: This location, somewhere in Benjamin, is not to be confused with the village of the same name in Zebulun ([1 Chr 6:77](#)). • Bethel: See study note on 1 Sam 7:16.

1 Samuel 10:5

Gibeah of God, Saul's hometown ([10:26](#)), had been a lawless city ([Judg 19-21](#)). Nowhere else is it described as being "of God." This description might point to God's ownership of the town despite the occupation of the Philistines. • band: Prophets often lived in groups (e.g., [2 Kgs 2:3](#)). • harp . . . lyre: Ancient prophets sometimes used musical instruments to stimulate and accompany prophesying (e.g., [2 Kgs 3:15](#)).

1 Samuel 10:6

prophecy: Cp. [2 Sam 23:2](#); [Acts 2:29–31](#). • different person: Saul would become a spiritual and charismatic national leader (cp. [1 Sam 16:14](#)).

1 Samuel 10:7

for God is with you: God's presence empowered Saul to carry out his responsibilities.

1 Samuel 10:8

Gilgal: See study note on 7:16. • wait for seven days: Saul apparently fulfilled this instruction in [11:14–15](#) (cp. [13:8](#)).

1 Samuel 10:9

a new heart: God gave Saul courage and strength, helping him overcome his hesitancy and enabling him to be king ([10:6](#)).

1 Samuel 10:10

the Spirit of God came powerfully upon Saul: See “The Spirit's Presence” Theme Note; see also [11:6](#); [Judg 14:6, 19](#); [15:14](#); cp. [Acts 2:17–18, 39](#). • When Saul . . . began to prophesy, it was a clear sign that he had been chosen to lead Israel (see also [1 Sam 19:18–23](#)).

1 Samuel 10:11

Those who knew Saul might have known him to be nonreligious and thus an unlikely candidate for prophet. Their surprise might indicate disappointment at receiving a prophet instead of a king (cp. [John 6:14–15](#)).

1 Samuel 10:12

“Can anyone become a prophet, no matter who his father is?” Unlike priests and kings, prophets never inherited their office. Possibly the people were asking why Saul, whose well-to-do father was well known, would associate himself with a group of people who had no pedigree.

1 Samuel 10:16

Perhaps Saul didn't tell his uncle because he had lingering uncertainty about what had transpired.

1 Samuel 10:17

An earlier generation had gathered at Mizpah to decimate the tribe of Benjamin ([Judg 20:1–4](#)), making the city an ironic place to inaugurate a man of Benjamin as king.

1 Samuel 10:18

rescued you . . . from all of the nations: Israel did not need a human king to rescue them; they needed God, but they had rejected him ([10:19](#)).

1 Samuel 10:19

rejected your God: See also [8:7](#). Israel was rejecting God's ability to protect and save them. • Clans are subdivisions of tribes.

1 Samuel 10:20

chosen by lot: Cp. [Lev 16:8](#); [Josh 18:6](#); [1 Chr 26:12–16](#); [Acts 1:26](#).

1 Samuel 10:25

rights and duties of a king: See [Deut 17:14–20](#). • He wrote them: Cp. [Exod 24:4](#); [Josh 24:26](#). • Samuel placed the document before the Lord—presumably in the Tabernacle. This position showed that God would honor those who lived by the covenant and punish those who violated it.

1 Samuel 10:26

whose hearts God had touched: God gave people confidence in Saul's ability to lead (cp. [10:9](#)).

1 Samuel 10:26–11.13

Saul proved his capacity for leadership by tolerating opposition and rescuing the town of Jabesh-gilead.

1 Samuel 10:27

These men were scoundrels (cp. [2:12](#)) because they scorned God's chosen king. • Gifts were given to show homage ([Gen 32:13](#), [18](#), [20](#)), political friendship ([2 Kgs 20:12](#)), or submission ([Judg 3:15](#), [17](#)). • ignored them: Saul's self-restraint while being insulted was a sign of maturity. In contrast, [Proverbs 16:14](#) speaks of a king's potentially explosive rage when somebody crosses him. See also [1 Sam 11:12–13](#). • [Nahash . . . Jabesh-gilead]: See NLT note. Whether this paragraph was part of the original text is uncertain, but it provides historical context for [11:1–15](#) (e.g., [11:2](#)).

1 Samuel 11:1

Ammon (see [Gen 19:38](#)), located on the east side of the Jordan, represented a threat to Israel similar to the Philistines to the southwest (see also [Judg 10:6–11:33](#)). • Make a treaty with us: Cp. [Josh 9](#); [2 Sam 10:19](#).

1 Samuel 11:1–15

Saul's kingship was confirmed through a military victory, the very reason the people wanted a king ([8:20](#)).

1 Samuel 11:2

gouge out the right eye: Mutilation of captured soldiers was a common practice in the ancient Near East. These disfigured soldiers would have lost all depth perception, seriously curtailing their potential for fighting in a revolt.

1 Samuel 11:3

Nahash agreed to grant a reprieve of seven days, reflecting his arrogant confidence of victory and his desire to humiliate Israel as much as possible.

1 Samuel 11:7

Not to participate would indicate rejection of the leadership of both Saul as king and Samuel as prophet.

1 Samuel 11:8

Bezek was about fourteen miles west of Jabesh-gilead. • The narrator's use of the terms Israel and Judah anticipates the later division of the kingdom ([1 Kgs 12](#)).

1 Samuel 11:13

No one will be executed: This was a time for rejoicing, not revenge.

1 Samuel 11:14

renew the kingdom: "Renew" indicates that someone or something had deteriorated or had been damaged (cp. [Ps 51:10](#)). Whatever effect the scoundrels ([1 Sam 10:27](#); [11:12](#)) might have had in undermining the people's confidence was now rectified by Saul's victory over the Ammonites.

1 Samuel 11:15

The solemn ceremony before the Lord acknowledged Saul's sovereignty as king while affirming that the Lord was Israel's true King. • Peace offerings were common on historic occasions that inaugurated important institutions (see [Exod 24:5](#); [Lev 9:4](#), [18](#), [22](#); [1 Kgs 8:63–64](#)).

1 Samuel 12:1–25

The reaffirmation of Saul's kingship at Gilgal ([11:12–15](#)) was the final step in his installation as king. The event was a fitting occasion for Samuel's farewell address as leader of Israel.

1 Samuel 12:3

God's anointed one was Saul (see [9:16](#)). • Whose ox or donkey: Cp. [Num 16:15](#). • have I stolen? In contrast to the behavior of kings ([1 Sam 8:11-16](#)). • Have I ever taken a bribe and perverted justice? No, but Samuel's sons did ([8:3](#)).

1 Samuel 12:5

my hands are clean: Samuel's life and leadership before Israel had been above reproach (cp. [1 Cor 9:1-14](#); [2 Cor 7:2](#); [11:7-9](#); [1 Thes 2:1-12](#)). Saul, David, and Solomon—kings rather than prophetic judges—would not be able to make this claim.

1 Samuel 12:6

Moses and Aaron were not self-made leaders but were appointed by God as leaders.

1 Samuel 12:6-25

In [12:1-5](#), Samuel put himself on trial and was found innocent. In [12:6-25](#), he put the nation on trial and found it guilty.

1 Samuel 12:9

handed them over: See [Judg 3:8](#); [4:1-3](#). • the king of Moab: See [Judg 3:12](#). Not all of Israel's enemies in the era of the judges are listed (e.g., the Ammonites and Midianites). This list is representative to emphasize the highs and lows of that era.

1 Samuel 12:10

Then they cried to the Lord: Sometimes only suffering turns people's hearts toward God. During the period of the judges, Israel repeatedly went through cycles of sin, oppression, repentance, and rescue. • Baal and Ashtoreth: When people turn away from God, they inevitably turn to idols (see [7:3](#); [Judg 2:13](#); [10:6](#)). • An attitude such as if you will rescue us turns worship into a debased bargain, in which God must perform some action to a person's liking. God deserves obedience and *worship* because he is God, not because of favors he can perform.

1 Samuel 12:11

- As in [1 Samuel 12:9](#), this list gives examples of some leaders.
- *Barak*: The Berean Standard Bible follows Greek and Syriac versions, which read "Barak" (see [Judges 4:6-24](#); [5:1](#), [12](#), [15](#)). Some translations follow the Hebrew, which reads "Bedan." We are not sure who this judge is.

1 Samuel 12:12

when you saw that Nahash ... was moving against you: Israel's trouble with Nahash likely started before the events described in [1 Samuel 11:1-11](#) (see [8:5](#), [20](#); [10:27](#)).

1 Samuel 12:13

Even though the Israelites' request amounted to a rejection of God as king, the Lord ... granted it (see study notes on [8:7](#) and [8:8](#)).

1 Samuel 12:14

Worship is meaningless if it does not result in obedience.

1 Samuel 12:14-15

To show that even under a monarchy Israel must still keep its covenant with the Lord—who was always to be their true king—Samuel echoed language from the Sinai covenant (e.g., [Exod 19:5-6](#); [Lev 26](#); [Deut 30:11-20](#)).

1 Samuel 12:17

The wheat harvest occurred in late spring or early summer, when little or no rain fell in Israel. Thunder and rain would thus demonstrate God's power as a sign of the people's wickedness in asking for a king.

1 Samuel 12:18

terrified: Cp. [Exod 19:16](#).

1 Samuel 12:19

The people asked Samuel to intercede for them (see also [7:8](#)) rather than praying themselves probably because they were out of fellowship with God (note the use of your God rather than “our God”). • added to our sins: The sins included idol worship ([12:21](#); see study note on 8:8).

1 Samuel 12:21

worthless . . . totally useless: Israel was slow to learn this lesson (e.g., [Isa 40:18–26](#); [44:9–20](#)).

1 Samuel 12:22

because that would dishonor his great name: God will never contradict his own character and detract from his glory (see also [Isa 37:35](#); [43:25](#); [48:9–11](#)). Therefore, he always keeps his covenant promises, even if his people do not. • his very own people: Israel is God’s treasured possession (see [Exod 19:5](#); [Deut 9:25–29](#)). He will never abandon them (see [Rom 11:1–5](#), [25–32](#)).

1 Samuel 12:23

I will continue to teach you: Samuel was both intercessor and educator. • Although this address marked the end of Samuel’s political leadership, he continued his spiritual ministry for some time (e.g., [19:24](#)).

1 Samuel 12:25

swept away: David later used this same Hebrew verb for Saul’s death ([26:10](#), “die . . . in battle”) and for his own possible death at Saul’s hands ([27:1](#), “get me”). The warning would remain in force throughout Israel’s history as a monarchy.

1 Samuel 13:1

For the kings of Israel and Judah, Scripture normally records the age of ascension and the length of reign (e.g., [2 Sam 5:4–5](#); [1 Kgs 14:21](#)). • thirty years old: The number represents a plausible age for Saul’s ascension. The Hebrew text and most Greek manuscripts omit the number, making it difficult to know the original wording. • reigned for forty-two years: See NLT textual note. Most scholars agree that something has fallen out of the original manuscript, most likely due to a copyist’s error. The majority of English translations have *forty-two* based on the approximate number in [Acts 13:21](#).

1 Samuel 13:1–16.13

Saul’s fall from power involved a threefold sequence, as had his rise to power (see study note on 9:1–11:15): (1) He offered the sacrifices himself and did not wait for Samuel ([13:1–14](#)); (2) he made a rash oath that put Jonathan’s life in danger ([14:1–46](#)); and (3) he failed to obey God by eliminating the Amalekites and their belongings ([15:1–35](#)).

1 Samuel 13:2

Earlier, Saul had employed 330,000 troops to fight against a much less formidable foe ([11:8](#)). The selection here of 3,000 special troops probably does not reflect overconfidence (cp. [Josh 7:3–4](#)). Rather, Saul likely recognized the need for a smaller, highly trained, elite militia to deal with the troublesome Philistines (see [1 Sam 14:52](#)). • Micmash was located in Benjamin about two miles northwest of Saul’s home in Gibeah.

1 Samuel 13:3

Geba was located between Jonathan’s forces at Gibeah and Saul’s forces at Micmash. A deep gorge separated Geba and Micmash (see [13:23](#); [14:5](#)). • The ram’s horn (Hebrew shofar) was used to raise a signal—e.g., to muster an army ([Judg 3:27](#)). For other uses, see [Lev 25:9](#); [2 Sam 6:15](#); [15:10](#); [18:16](#); [20:1](#); [Hos 5:8](#); [Joel 2:15](#). • Non-Israelites often used the term Hebrews disdainfully (see [1 Sam 14:11](#); [29:3](#); see also [Gen 39:14](#); [43:32](#)). Saul might have used it to strike a nerve and arouse the people’s pride in their identity.

1 Samuel 13:4

Saul had destroyed: The commander in chief often got credit for what his soldiers accomplished. • Saul's kingship had been reaffirmed at Gilgal ([11:15](#)). Now the Lord would reject his kingship there because of his disobedience ([13:7-14](#)).

1 Samuel 13:5

The Israelites were massively outnumbered, hence their fearful responses. • The Philistine army's 3,000 chariots and 6,000 charioteers indicate Israel's underdog status. Nowhere in 1 Samuel is Israel said to have had any chariots (see study note on 13:19-22).

1 Samuel 13:7

The land of Gad and Gilead ran the length of Transjordan (the region just east of the Jordan River).

1 Samuel 13:8

seven days . . . as Samuel had instructed: This instruction most likely was not the instruction in [10:8](#) but an unrecorded instruction on a separate occasion (see study note on 10:8).

1 Samuel 13:9

the burnt offering and the peace offerings: These general-purpose offerings (see [Exod 24:5](#); [32:6](#); [Num 10:10](#); [15:8](#); [Deut 27:6-7](#)) were always offered on a solemn occasion filled with either danger or joy. Typically, only priests were to offer these sacrifices (but see study note on 1 Sam 13:13).

1 Samuel 13:10

meet and welcome: Saul seemed unaware he had done anything wrong.

1 Samuel 13:11

What is this you have done? Samuel's question was a rebuke, not a request for information (cp. [Gen 3:13](#)).

1 Samuel 13:12

asked for the Lord's help: The purpose of the burnt offering was to entreat God to grant victory in battle. Samuel himself had offered a similar sacrifice, which did lead to victory in battle (see [7:7-11](#)). But Samuel, unlike Saul, served in a priestly role.

1 Samuel 13:13

the command the Lord . . . gave you: Other kings offered sacrifices without censure (David, [2 Sam 6:13, 17-18](#); Solomon, [1 Kgs 3:15](#); [8:64](#); Ahaz, [2 Kgs 16:12-13](#)), as did judges (Gideon, [Judg 6:26](#)), illustrating that on occasion non-priests could conduct sacrifices in a way that pleased the Lord. However, Samuel, God's prophet, had given Saul the order to wait (see study note on 1 Sam 13:8).

1 Samuel 13:14

a man after his own heart: This prophecy pertains to David (see also [Acts 13:22](#)) rather than to Saul's son Jonathan. The rejection of Saul was also the rejection of his family dynasty.

1 Samuel 13:15

only 600 were left: Most of the 3,000 troops ([13:2](#)) had abandoned Saul ([13:6-7](#)).

1 Samuel 13:17-18

Armies would send out raiding parties to plunder and sow panic among the enemy. These raiders embarked north (Ophrah), west (Beth-horon), and east (Zeboim), but not south, where Israelite strength was consolidated and where the terrain did not allow easy movement of forces (see study note on 13:23).

1 Samuel 13:19–22

no blacksmiths: The Philistines kept the Israelites unarmed by gaining a monopoly on the iron necessary to make weapons. Iron technology had not existed long in Canaan; it might have developed in the Aegean area, and metalworking skills were possibly introduced into Canaan through seafaring peoples, including the Philistines.

1 Samuel 13:23

The pass at Micmash was a strategic passage through the canyon that separated Micmash from Geba, Gibeah, and other towns to the south.

1 Samuel 14:1

armor bearer: See study note on 16:21. • Jonathan did not tell his father because he knew that Saul would not grant permission for the dangerous plan. But he also knew that Saul wanted no one—not even his own son—to upstage him.

1 Samuel 14:1–15

Jonathan again fought in his father's battles (see also [13:2–4](#); ch [31](#)).

1 Samuel 14:1–52

Saul's behavior in this chapter further justifies his dismissal as king ([13:8–14](#); see also ch [15](#)). Saul was alienated from both Samuel and his heroic son Jonathan. [Chapter 14](#) anticipates the significant role that Jonathan played in the transition from Saul's kingship to David's.

1 Samuel 14:2

camped: Saul's inactivity contrasts with Jonathan's initiative (see also [22:6](#)).

1 Samuel 14:3

Ahijah the priest was an adviser who could give Saul divine guidance through the ephod ([14:18–19](#); see also [2:18](#) and corresponding study note; [23:9–](#)

[10](#)). • son of Eli: Saul, the rejected king ([13:13–14](#)), kept in his company a priest from the rejected priesthood ([2:27–36](#)). • Ichabod: See [4:21](#).

1 Samuel 14:4–5

The Philistines had already secured this area ([13:23](#)), so Jonathan and his armor bearer had to move carefully.

1 Samuel 14:6

pagans (literally *uncircumcised*): A disdainful term for enemies of Israel (see also [17:36](#); [31:4](#)). • Perhaps: Jonathan had no guarantee of survival, but he was certain that God could grant them victory despite the odds. Victory was in God's hands; Jonathan offered himself as an instrument God could use. • many warriors or only a few: Jonathan knew what Gideon had learned many years earlier (see [Judg 7:2–8](#)).

1 Samuel 14:11

Hebrews: See study note on 13:3. • crawling out of their holes: See [13:6](#).

1 Samuel 14:15

panic broke out: This parallel with the Gideon story depicts Jonathan as a judge-like figure (cp. [Judg 7:19–22](#)). God had not anointed or expressly gifted Jonathan to be leader, yet God used him to rescue his people. • raiding parties: See study note on 1 Sam 13:17–18.

1 Samuel 14:18

Bring . . . Israelites: See NLT textual note; the Greek text is likely original. The Ark remained at Kiriath-jearim for twenty years ([7:2](#)), and it was never used for getting information about the future, as the ephod was (see study note on 2:18).

1 Samuel 14:21–22

Previously, a large group of Israelites had gone into hiding out of fear ([13:6–7](#)). Others might have joined the Philistine army. However, the statement that they revolted when the opportunity arose suggests they might have been taken as prisoners of war and forced into the Philistines' service.

1 Samuel 14:23

It was God, not Saul, who saved Israel; Jonathan was just a willing instrument in the Lord's hands. • Beth-aven was due west of Micmash (see [13:5](#)). The Israelites forced the Philistines to retreat all the way to Aijalon that day (see [14:31](#)).

1 Samuel 14:24

With his oath, Saul forced abstinence from food on men who were already hungry and exhausted from battle. This oath was probably a pagan-like attempt to manipulate God into giving them a favorable result (cp. notes on [Exod 23:26](#); [25:22](#); [32:4](#)). • That Saul said my enemies rather than "our enemies" reflects his self-centered pride.

1 Samuel 14:29

made trouble: Joshua had used this verb in speaking with Achan ([Josh 7:25](#)), and Jephthah had used it with his innocent daughter ([Judg 11:35](#)). Saul's foolish oath limited Israel's victory ([1 Sam 14:30](#)) and put his son's life at risk (see also [Josh 6:18](#); [1 Chr 2:7](#)).

1 Samuel 14:31

Aijalon: If the Philistines fled along the likely route through Beth-horon, then the Israelites kept up the pursuit for close to twenty miles.

1 Samuel 14:32–34

The men were famished, so they ate meat without draining the blood. This act violated God's law (see [Lev 17:10–14](#)) and thus constituted sinning against the Lord. To prevent more sin, Saul used a large rock as a field altar so that the animals' blood could

be properly drained. The incident would never have occurred had it not been for Saul's foolish oath.

1 Samuel 14:35

first of the altars: This altar is the only one mentioned. David later built an altar that would become the site of God's Temple ([2 Sam 24:18–25](#)).

1 Samuel 14:37–38

God made no reply: Neither the "no" lot nor the "yes" lot of the Urim and Thummim appeared.

1 Samuel 14:41

Casting sacred lots involved the Urim and Thummim ([Exod 28:30](#); [Lev 8:8](#)), which David also used when soliciting God's guidance ([1 Sam 23:2](#); [30:8](#); [2 Sam 2:1](#)). The Urim and Thummim were two small objects (perhaps flat stones, sticks, or arrows) that may have been cast like dice. They would provide a positive answer, a neutral response, or a negative answer.

1 Samuel 14:45

The people, aware of God's blessing on the real hero of the day, were wiser than their king.

1 Samuel 14:47

secured his grasp: Samuel had used this verb repeatedly when speaking about what a king would do: "He will take . . . take . . . take" ([8:10–18](#)). • Moab, Ammon, Edom, . . . Zobah: David confronted these same foes during his reign and expanded Israel's territory in the process (see [2 Sam 8:1–14](#)).

1 Samuel 14:47–52

In contrast to the folly described in [14:1–46](#), these verses summarize Saul's military successes. A similar summary of achievements ends the description of each king's reign in 1 Samuel—2 Kings.

1 Samuel 14:48

conquered the Amalekites: See [15:1-35](#). The Amalekites, a nomadic group in the south, periodically raided and pillaged Israel (see [Exod 17:8-16](#); [Num 14:45](#); [Judg 3:13](#); [6:3](#), [33](#); [7:12](#); [10:12](#)).

1 Samuel 14:49

Saul's sons included: Another of Saul's sons was named Abinadab ([31:2](#)). • Ishbosheth means "man of shame" (see study note on 2 Sam 2:8). He was also called Esh-baal ("man of Baal"). He served briefly as a rival king over the northern tribes during David's early years ([2 Sam 2:8-11](#)).

1 Samuel 14:49-51

This information about Saul's family, placed here rather than at the end of his reign, hints that his reign was essentially over and he would not be succeeded by one of his sons.

1 Samuel 14:50

Ahinoam is mentioned only here in Saul's story. In [25:43](#), David marries a woman also called Ahinoam (who might or might not have been the same person; cp. [2 Sam 12:8](#)).

1 Samuel 14:52

Saul had easily defeated the Ammonites ([11:11](#)) but was having much less success with the Philistines, given their well-organized fighting machine and their monopoly on iron and bronze ([13:19-22](#)). • he drafted him: Samuel had warned earlier that the king would take people as well as possessions ([8:11](#)).

1 Samuel 15:1-35

After Saul failed to obey God and completely destroy the Amalekites, God rejected him in even stronger terms than before (cp. [13:8-14](#)).

1 Samuel 15:2

Lord of Heaven's Armies: See study note on 1:3. • to settle accounts: In Moses' time, the nation of Amalek had inhabited southern Judah and the Negev area south of Judah. As Israel traveled to Canaan, the Amalekites preyed on the sick and the weak and those traveling at the rear. They were the first people to attack Israel after the exodus from Egypt, for which God had promised to judge them ([Exod 17:8-16](#); [Deut 25:17-19](#)).

1 Samuel 15:3

completely destroy: See "Complete Dedication" Theme Note.

1 Samuel 15:4

Telaim: Possibly Telem ([Josh 15:24](#)).

1 Samuel 15:5

The unnamed town in the valley was located somewhere near a Negev *wadi*, a streambed or riverbed that fills with water only when rain falls.

1 Samuel 15:6

The Kenites were nomadic metalworkers and descendants of Moses' father-in-law ([Judg 1:16](#)). • you showed kindness: See [Exod 18](#); [Num 10:29-32](#).

1 Samuel 15:7

The area where the Amalekites lived stretched from Havilah in northern Sinai to Shur near the eastern border of Egypt.

1 Samuel 15:8

Agag was probably the descendant of an earlier king by the same name (see [Num 24:7](#); cp. [Esth 3:1](#)).

1 Samuel 15:9

Saul and his men directly disobeyed the Lord's command to "completely destroy" the Amalekites ([15:3](#)). Though the entire army participated in the disobedience of God's command, Saul alone was responsible as their leader.

1 Samuel 15:12

Carmel was a town near Hebron in southern Judah.
 • Saul commemorated his own accomplishments by erecting a monument to himself. In reality, he had earned shame ([15:16-19](#)). • Gilgal: See [13:4](#).

1 Samuel 15:13

I have carried out the Lord's command! Cp. [15:3](#). Saul apparently thought his actions were justified ([15:15](#); cp. [Lev 22:19](#)). Samuel, however, cut through Saul's pretense ([1 Sam 15:17-19](#)) and carried out God's command himself ([15:32-33](#)).

1 Samuel 15:15

Saul blamed the army even though he was the commander. Certainly, his real motivation was not spiritual ([15:9](#)).

1 Samuel 15:17

As the anointed . . . king of Israel, Saul bore the responsibility for disobeying God, which neither false humility nor making excuses could diminish.

1 Samuel 15:21

my troops: Saul persisted in blaming others (see [15:15](#)). • Gilgal was a religious center. Saul tried to use religion to justify disobedience to God.

1 Samuel 15:22

What is more pleasing: God values obedience much more than ritual (see also [Ps 40:6](#); [Hos 6:6](#); [Matt 12:7](#)). • the fat of rams: The choicest parts of the animal were offered to God.

1 Samuel 15:23

Rebellion . . . and stubbornness, sins of the heart, are as bad as the sinful practices of idolatrous pagans. • Scripture condemns witchcraft (see study note on Deut 18:10).

1 Samuel 15:24

I was afraid of the people: Saul continued to blame others (see [15:15](#), [21](#)). • what they demanded: There is no hint of such pressure in the chapter. Saul's confession appears dishonest (cp. David, [2 Sam 12:13](#); [Ps 51](#)).

1 Samuel 15:24-30

Saul finally confessed his sin. But it was too little, too late—and still accompanied by excuses.

1 Samuel 15:28

Saul soon discovered who this someone else was ([18:8-9](#); cp. ch [16](#)).

1 Samuel 15:29

nor will he change his mind: Samuel spoke prophetically of God's commitment to make David king and to preserve his dynasty. God had rejected Saul, but he would never reject David (see [2 Sam 7:8-17](#)).

1 Samuel 15:30

honor me before the elders: To help Saul save face.

1 Samuel 15:35

The verb phrase mourned constantly is usually used for grieving over someone's death. Although Saul was still living, his royalty was coming to an end. Samuel might have been grieving out of personal attachment to Saul, a sense of failure, or concern that Israel's condition would be worse. •

the Lord was sorry: See “God’s Change of Mind” Theme Note.

1 Samuel 16:1

mourned long enough: See study note on 15:35. • Bethlehem was about five miles south of Jerusalem. It was later known as the City of David ([Luke 2:11](#)) and the birthplace of Jesus. • Jesse was the grandson of Boaz and Ruth ([Ruth 4:22](#)). • I have selected: This Hebrew verb implies that God had seen one of [Jesse’s] sons and based his choice on what he saw. God, the eternal king, knows better than the people of Israel how to choose a good king to serve the nation, and he provided a replacement for Saul who would lead Israel well.

1 Samuel 16:1–23

David was Saul’s replacement. There are striking similarities between the two: Samuel anointed both. Neither was pursuing the position. Both were unlikely candidates (Saul was from the smallest tribe; David was the youngest son). Both were impressive in appearance ([9:2](#); [16:12](#)). And the Spirit came mightily on each when he was anointed king ([10:10](#); [11:6](#); [16:13](#)). The key difference was that David was “a man after [God’s] own heart” ([13:14](#); cp. [16:7](#)), while Saul was not.

1 Samuel 16:2

say that you have come to make a sacrifice: God sometimes leads his servants into dangerous situations. He protects his own—sometimes by miracle, sometimes by strategy (cp. [Exod 3:18–22](#)). In Samuel’s role as a priestly judge, he would not have raised any suspicions by offering a sacrifice (see [1 Sam 10:8](#)).

1 Samuel 16:4

the elders . . . came trembling: News of Samuel’s rebuke of Saul and execution of Agag had likely reached Bethlehem.

1 Samuel 16:5

Purify yourselves: Self-purification included bathing and abstaining from sexual intercourse (see [Exod 19:10–15](#); cp. [Gen 35:2–4](#)). • The sacrifice likely took place the following morning (see [Num 11:18](#); [Josh 3:5](#); [7:13–14](#)). • Samuel performed the purification rite for Jesse and his sons to make sure they were ready for the sacrifice and for the anointing of the new king (cp. [Exod 19:10](#); [Josh 3:5](#)).

1 Samuel 16:6–7

his appearance or height: Like Saul, Eliab, Jesse’s oldest son, had an impressive outward appearance (cp. [9:2](#)). Also like Saul, he was rejected (cp. [15:23](#)). God had another man in mind to anoint as king. • the Lord looks at the heart: God can give a new heart ([10:9](#)), touch hearts ([10:26](#)), and peer into the deep motivations of the heart ([Ps 139:1](#)). God sees what people cannot see—a person’s true character. Eliab’s character comes out in [1 Sam 17:28](#).

1 Samuel 16:13

The Spirit of the Lord came . . . upon David, as was consistently evident (e.g., [16:23](#); [17:48–54](#); [18:5, 12–16](#)). The Spirit of the Lord had also come upon Saul ([10:10](#)) but had left him because of disobedience ([16:14](#)). • Ramah: Samuel’s hometown ([1:1](#)).

1 Samuel 16:14

Spirit . . . left Saul: In contrast with David’s receiving the Spirit (see “The Spirit’s Presence” Theme Note). • The Lord sent a tormenting spirit as a consequence of Saul’s disobedience (see also [18:10](#); [19:9](#); cp. [Judg 9:23](#); [Rom 1:28–29](#)).

1 Samuel 16:14–31.13

Saul’s kingship continued its downward spiral after God’s Spirit departed from him. His reign ended in shame and defeat (ch [31](#)).

1 Samuel 16:18

harp: The instrument was probably a lyre (as in [10:5](#)). • the Lord is with him: People recognized that God's Spirit was upon David ([16:13](#)).

1 Samuel 16:21

Although at first Saul loved David very much, this love soon turned to intense jealousy and hatred (see [18:8–14](#)). • An armor bearer in ancient Israel served as the personal attendant of a warrior chieftain (see [14:1–15](#); [31:4–6](#); [Judg 9:54](#); [2 Sam 18:15](#)).

1 Samuel 16:22

David's father, Jesse ([16:18](#)), arranged for David to continue serving Saul while still fulfilling his shepherding duties at home (see [17:14–15](#)).

1 Samuel 16:23

Saul would feel better: David was more than a handsome lad gifted in music; he was the anointed king. Here David illustrated what a king should be: one who brings relief. Later, David composed dozens of psalms that have brought comfort and relief through the ages. • the tormenting spirit would go away: Even those who are disobedient and rejected can receive relief and comfort through the Lord's servant.

1 Samuel 17:1

The Philistines presented an ongoing threat throughout Saul's reign (see [14:47–52](#)). • Socoh in Judah was fourteen miles west of Bethlehem toward Philistine territory. • Azekah was a few miles northwest of Socoh (the precise location of Ephes-dammim is unknown). The Philistines were encroaching on Israelite territory.

1 Samuel 17:2

The valley of Elah was a fertile area that ran east–west, fifteen miles southwest of Bethlehem.

1 Samuel 17:4

champion: In ancient times, rival forces would sometimes agree to let selected individuals from each side decide a conflict. This reduced casualties and other costs. The same kind of combat is reflected in [2 Sam 2:12–17](#). • Gath was one of five Philistine cities with a reputation for having giants as citizens ([2 Sam 21:15–22](#)).

1 Samuel 17:5–7

Although Goliath was a fully armored warrior of terrifying size, he did not have God—a far mightier warrior—on his side ([17:45–47](#)).

1 Samuel 17:12

Ephrathite: Ephrath is a name for Bethlehem ([Gen 35:19](#); [1 Chr 4:4](#)).

1 Samuel 17:15

went back and forth: David apparently served as a musician and armor bearer in Saul's court (see [16:19–23](#)) while maintaining his duties at home. The intermittent nature of David's service might explain why Saul was unfamiliar with David during the encounter with Goliath (see [17:55–58](#)).

1 Samuel 17:26

What will a man get: Cp. [18:17–27](#). David's interest in a reward was overshadowed by his determination to silence Goliath's defiance of God ([17:45–47](#)). • pagan: Literally *uncircumcised*. See study note on 14:6.

1 Samuel 17:28

Eliab . . . was angry, perhaps resentful that David, rather than he, was anointed to be king ([16:6–13](#)).

1 Samuel 17:32

I'll go fight him! David's courage stands in contrast to Saul's fear ([17:11](#)).

1 Samuel 17:40

A stream flowed through the valley of Elah ([17:2](#)).
 • A sling was a leather pouch attached to two leather thongs. When the sling containing a stone was whirled rapidly, one of the thongs could be released, sending the stone toward its target. David probably became deadly accurate with a sling as a shepherd, but the sling was used by warriors as well ([Judg 20:16](#)).

1 Samuel 17:42

ruddy-faced: The same Hebrew word is translated “dark” ([16:12](#)) and “very red” ([Gen 25:25](#)). Here, it emphasizes David’s youthfulness and inexperience.
 • boy: Saul had expressed similar disbelief ([1 Sam 17:33](#)). As a champion, Goliath expected to be met by an Israelite warrior of similar rank.

1 Samuel 17:43

a dog: A metaphor for a compliant, bowing servant (cp. [2 Sam 9:8](#)).
 • a stick: David had concealed his sling, and Goliath could see only his staff.
 • by the names of his gods: Since Goliath appealed to his gods, David’s victory over Goliath would also symbolize God’s victory over Dagon, the chief god of the Philistines ([1 Sam 5:2, 5](#)).

1 Samuel 17:44

A corpse left to scavengers such as birds and wild animals was grievously cursed (cp. [Deut 21:23; 28:26](#)).

1 Samuel 17:45–47

the Lord of Heaven’s Armies: See study note on 1:3. Despite the Philistines’ apparent military advantage, David knew that Israel had the supreme advantage in the one true God.

1 Samuel 17:49

Goliath’s forehead remained exposed beneath his enormous helmet.
 • stumbled and fell face down: The stone only incapacitated Goliath; David killed him by decapitating him ([17:51](#)).

1 Samuel 17:52

The Israelites chased the Philistines to Gath, some six miles to the west.
 • Ekron was a Philistine city five miles north of Gath.
 • Shaaraim was a city of Judah near Azekah ([17:1](#)).

1 Samuel 17:53

Unless expressly prohibited (e.g., [15:3](#); [Josh 6:18](#)), victory in battle allowed for the taking of war spoils ([Deut 2:35](#); [Josh 8:2](#)).

1 Samuel 17:54

Jerusalem became an Israelite city later, when David captured it from the Jebusites ([2 Sam 5:6–7](#)). Jerusalem was probably the final destination of Goliath’s head, after David had become king. But David might have taken it to Jerusalem earlier to intimidate the non-Israelite occupants.

1 Samuel 17:55–58

In light of [16:14–23](#), it is surprising that neither Saul nor Abner knew who David was. It is possible that the events of ch [17](#) happened either before or long after David’s tenure of intermittent service mentioned in ch [16](#) (Saul probably served as king for forty-two years, [13:1](#)).

1 Samuel 18:1

David and Jonathan had much in common: both were young and capable, were military heroes, had a robust faith in God, and had a claim to the throne of Israel. It is a testimony to Jonathan’s true character that he recognized and supported God’s choice of David to be the next king of Israel (see [18:3–4](#); [20:12–17](#)).
 • Jonathan loved David: See [20:17](#); [2 Sam 1:26](#). Others in this chapter are also said to love David: all Israel and Judah ([1 Sam](#)

[18:16](#)), Saul's daughter Michal ([18:20](#)), and Saul's servants ([18:22](#)). Some modern interpreters see a homosexual relationship between David and Jonathan, but the text implies nothing other than a deep and loyal friendship.

1 Samuel 18:2

David had previously served Saul part-time (see [17:15](#) and corresponding study note); now Saul kept David with him full-time.

1 Samuel 18:3-4

Out of his love for David and recognition that God had chosen David to be Israel's next king (see [20:13-17](#), [30-31](#); [23:17](#)), Jonathan made a solemn pact of friendship with David. By giving David items that symbolized his official status as the king's son and crown prince, Jonathan symbolically gave David his right of succession to the throne.

1 Samuel 18:7

thousands . . . ten thousands: This dramatic increase in number between two lines of Hebrew poetry was a way of intensifying the statement (cp. [Deut 32:30](#); [Ps 91:7](#)). Because of his great military victories, David was beginning to eclipse Saul ([1 Sam 18:16](#), [30](#); [21:11](#)).

1 Samuel 18:8-15

Saul came to view David as a threat rather than an ally and would do anything to get rid of him.

1 Samuel 18:11

In his jealousy and fear, Saul would have been happier with one dead David than with thousands of dead Philistines ([18:7](#)).

1 Samuel 18:12

the Lord . . . had turned away from Saul as king as punishment for his disobedience. Saul's kingship would fail, and David's would succeed ([18:14](#)).

1 Samuel 18:17

Saul had promised his daughter to anyone who could slay Goliath ([17:25](#); cp. [Josh 15:16](#); [Judg 1:12](#)), but he tacked on additional risks for David (see also [1 Sam 18:21](#), [25](#)).

1 Samuel 18:17-19

Saul offered his older daughter, Merab, to David. But it was an insincere gesture.

1 Samuel 18:18

Who am I, and what is my family: An expression of humility (see also [2 Sam 7:18](#); cp. [Exod 3:11](#)). David's family could not afford the bride price to marry the king's daughter ([1 Sam 18:23-25](#)).

1 Samuel 18:19

So: Or *But*. Either David declined the offer, or Saul reneged.

1 Samuel 18:22

really likes you: The same Hebrew word describes Jonathan's love for David ([18:3](#); [19:1-2](#), "strong affection"). Here, it was completely untrue.

1 Samuel 18:23

The future son-in-law would give the bride price as a gift to his bride's father (see [Gen 34:12](#); [Exod 22:16-17](#)).

1 Samuel 18:29

even more afraid: Saul's fear was unfounded. Although he made himself David's enemy, David consistently honored Saul as king (see chs [24](#), [26](#)).

1 Samuel 19:4

Jonathan addressed his father as the king out of reverence.

1 Samuel 19:6

vowed: Violating a vow is a serious offense against God (see [Num 30:2](#); [Deut 23:21-23](#); cp. [Eccl 5:4-5](#)). But Saul soon disregarded his promise and again sought to kill David ([1 Sam 19:9-24](#)).

1 Samuel 19:10

hurled his spear: See also [18:11](#); [20:33](#).

1 Samuel 19:11

See [Psalm 59:1](#).

1 Samuel 19:13

an idol: Hebrew teraphim, which were household idols (see [Gen 31:30](#); [Judg 17:5](#); [2 Kgs 23:24](#)). The presence of an idol in the home of David and Michal might show the pervasive influence of pagan idol worship among the Israelites; perhaps the idol belonged to Michal. Apparently David did not object to its presence. (Cp. Rachel's theft of her father's household idols in [Gen 31:19](#).) • Siblings Jonathan ([1 Sam 19:1-7](#)) and Michal ([19:11-18](#)) saved David from their father and undermined their father's plans to eliminate him. Members of Saul's royal family played a significant role in David's rise, though David did not usurp Saul's throne.

1 Samuel 19:18

Ramah: Samuel's hometown ([1:1](#)). • Naioth was a tiny village not far from the other Ramah in Benjamin.

1 Samuel 19:20

Prophets often assembled in groups under a single leader (see [2 Kgs 2:15](#); [4:38](#); [6:1-7](#)). • The Spirit of

God came upon Saul's men to allow David to escape ([1 Sam 20:1](#)).

1 Samuel 19:21

other troops . . . a third time: Each time Saul sent troops, David's would-be captors were captured by the Spirit. Prophesying diverted them from pursuing David.

1 Samuel 19:24

When Saul tore off his clothes and lay naked, he unwittingly acted out his true spiritual condition of having been stripped of the kingship ([13:14](#); [15:10-11](#), [23](#); see "Prophetic Sign Acts" Theme Note). • Is even Saul a prophet? In [1 Sam 10:9-13](#), Saul was rising as God's chosen king; here, he is descending under the weight of God's rejection.

1 Samuel 20:2-3

Jonathan was naive about his father's intentions. David's willingness to swear . . . by the Lord showed how convinced he was about Saul's intentions.

1 Samuel 20:5

new moon festival: The ancient Hebrews followed a lunar calendar, and the new moon marked the start of a new month. Every month was begun with a special sacrifice ([Num 28:11-15](#)), which became a monthly festival.

1 Samuel 20:6-7

Israelite families might designate one of the new moon festivals as an opportunity for an annual family sacrifice (see, e.g., [1:3](#)).

1 Samuel 20:8

Loyalty (Hebrew *khesed*) denotes faithfulness between covenant partners. • a solemn pact: See [18:3](#); [20:16](#).

1 Samuel 20:13

may the Lord strike me: Jonathan invoked a curse upon himself to reassure David that he would keep his promise. • as he used to be with my father: Jonathan recognized that David had received the blessing from God that his father had once had. The divine favor that had brought Saul into royal office ([9:14–10:1](#)) would bring David into royal office as Saul's replacement. Jonathan accepted this even though he was the natural successor to Saul.

1 Samuel 20:14–16

faithful love: Hebrew *khesed* (see study note on 20:8). Jonathan was reminding David to keep his commitment to him when he became king. It was reasonable for Jonathan to be concerned that David might kill any descendant of Saul who could make a rival claim to his throne. Saul later made a similar request of David ([24:21](#)).

1 Samuel 20:15

treat my family: David later treated Jonathan's son, Mephibosheth, as one of his own sons ([2 Sam 9:1–13](#)).

1 Samuel 20:17

See [1 Samuel 18:3](#) and [23:16–18](#).

1 Samuel 20:18–22

Jonathan's ruse would allow David to get the message even if there could be no face-to-face meeting; the boy's presence would allay suspicion and provide Jonathan an alibi for going to the field. As it happened, no one but the boy accompanied Jonathan to the field, so when the boy left, David was able to speak with Jonathan face to face ([20:40–42](#)).

1 Samuel 20:25

Abner was Saul's cousin and served as commander of Saul's army ([14:50](#); [17:55](#)). His importance is indicated by his position beside the king at this festival.

1 Samuel 20:26–27

A number of circumstances could render a person ceremonially unclean and thus unfit for attending a sacred festival (see [Lev 7:20–21](#)). Often, an unclean person was required to be excluded from such functions only until the evening of the same day ([Lev 15](#)). This explains why Saul became suspicious after David did not arrive the next day. • Saul referred to David as the son of Jesse (also in [1 Sam 20:31](#); [22:7](#)), a description that functioned as David's surname.

1 Samuel 20:29

get away: This verb also describes David's earlier escape from Saul ([19:10–12](#), [17–18](#)).

1 Samuel 20:30

You stupid son of a whore! This epithet was as strong and insulting in Hebrew as it is in English. • shaming yourself: Saul was interested in the legacy of his own dynasty. He viewed David's actions as ultimately directed against Jonathan, the hereditary successor. To Saul, Jonathan was stupidly hurting and *shaming* himself by supporting David.

1 Samuel 20:33

hurled his spear at Jonathan: See also [18:11](#); [19:10](#). • at last Jonathan realized: Jonathan had been reluctant to believe the truth about his own father ([20:2–3](#)), but he could no longer deny it.

1 Samuel 20:41

David bowed: Jonathan had the higher social rank, so David's homage was fitting. • Both of them were in tears: For the first time, the record of the emotion between these two men shows mutuality (see [18:1](#), [3–4](#); [20:17](#)).

1 Samuel 20:42

sworn loyalty to each other in the Lord's name: See [18:3](#); [20:15-17](#); [23:16-18](#).

1 Samuel 21:1

Nob was just north of Jerusalem, in the southern part of the territory of Benjamin. • Ahimelech the priest was a descendant of the condemned family of Eli ([14:3](#); [22:9](#)). • The elders of Bethlehem had also trembled when Samuel unexpectedly came to their city to anoint David as Saul's replacement ([16:4](#)). On both occasions, a prominent individual who had strained relations with Saul showed up unannounced. Both Ahimelech and the Bethlehem elders were concerned about being suspected of supporting an enemy of the king, which could result in death. In this case, what was feared came about (see [22:9-19](#)).

1 Samuel 21:2

The king has sent me: David lied to conceal his outlaw status and to dispel Ahimelech's worries.

1 Samuel 21:4

Only priests were permitted to partake of holy bread (see [Exod 25:22-30](#); [Lev 24:5-9](#)), and only within the sacred precincts. • slept with any women: The consecrated bread was to be eaten only by the ritually pure, so the priest verified that David's men were free from ritual impurity caused by sexual activity (see [Lev 15:16-18](#)). Typically, such bread would not be available for consumption by laity. The priest made an exception in this case probably because he sensed the men's physical needs and he believed they were on a royal mission.

1 Samuel 21:6

gave him the holy bread: Jesus referred to this incident to teach that meeting people's physical needs takes precedence over rigid adherence to sacred institutions (see [Matt 12:1-8](#); [Mark 2:23-28](#); [Luke 6:1-5](#)). • The Bread of the Presence consisted of twelve loaves (possibly one representing each tribe) that were laid out on a

table in the Holy Place. They were replaced every Sabbath (see [Exod 25:30](#); [Lev 24:5-9](#)).

1 Samuel 21:7

having been detained before the Lord: Ahimelech sought guidance from God on others' behalf ([22:15](#)), so it is possible that Doeg was awaiting a response to an inquiry.

1 Samuel 21:9

The sword of Goliath, which David used to decapitate the giant ([17:51](#)), had been taken as war spoils, as had Goliath's head ([17:54](#)). • The ephod mentioned here might not have been the priestly garment of the same name; some passages give the impression that an ephod could also be a statue ([Judg 8:27](#); [18:17](#)).

1 Samuel 21:10-15

Gath, a major Philistine city and the hometown of Goliath, was a clever but dangerous place for David to seek refuge from Saul.

1 Samuel 21:11

the king of the land: David's reputation as a mighty warrior even greater than King Saul (see [18:7](#)) had grown to the point where foreigners began referring to him as Israel's king.

1 Samuel 21:12-13

The lengthy title of [Ps 34](#) refers to this incident but names the Philistine king Abimelech rather than Achish. "Abimelech" might have been the common title for Philistine kings (in Hebrew it means "my father the king"). The name Abimelech also appears in [Gen 20:2](#); [26:1](#).

1 Samuel 22:1

Adullam was some sixteen miles southwest of Jerusalem, near Philistine territory. • Had David's brothers and all his other relatives stayed in

Bethlehem, they would have been vulnerable to Saul's revenge.

1 Samuel 22:1–23

Saul's character becomes evident here. Unable to exact revenge on David himself, Saul slaughtered those he believed to be guilty of giving aid and comfort to David.

1 Samuel 22:2

in trouble . . . in debt . . . discontented: By attracting such down-and-out people to himself, David foreshadowed Jesus, who would attract to himself the hurting, the burdened, and the outcast ([Matt 11:25–30](#)).

1 Samuel 22:3–4

Mizpeh in Moab lay east of the Dead Sea and the Jordan River—not an easy trip from Adullam, especially if the 400 men ([22:2](#)) accompanied David. • David's parents stayed in Moab: Jesse's grandmother was Ruth, a Moabite ([Ruth 4:13–22](#)).

1 Samuel 22:5

The prophet Gad was David's special adviser ([2 Sam 24:11](#)). God was no longer communicating with Saul but was guiding David.

1 Samuel 22:7–8

men of Benjamin: Saul was suspicious of his own tribesmen, believing that David had bought their loyalty. Worse, Saul did not even trust his own son, convinced that he had joined the supposed conspiracy.

1 Samuel 22:13

David had deceived Ahimelech into thinking he was on a mission for Saul ([21:1–9](#)), so Saul's accusations of conspiracy were baseless.

1 Samuel 22:14

your son-in-law: David had married Saul's daughter ([18:17–29](#)).

1 Samuel 22:18

Doeg the Edomite . . . killed them: As a non-Israelite, Doeg had no concern for the sanctity of God-anointed priests. He knew he was executing innocent men. This evil foreigner partially fulfilled the prophecy about the condemned priestly line of Eli ([2:27–34](#); see [1 Kgs 2:27](#)). • still wearing their priestly garments: This incident illustrates how mad Saul had become. Not even those holding a sacred office were safe.

1 Samuel 22:19

Saul had been unwilling to carry out God's orders to destroy completely the Amalekites and their possessions ([15:3](#), [9](#)). Yet now, in his rage, he did not hesitate to decimate the priests' families and their possessions (see [Prov 14:29](#); [16:14](#); [27:4](#)).

1 Samuel 22:20

Abiathar became an adviser to David, providing guidance from the Lord through the ephod ([23:2–12](#); [2 Sam 15:24–36](#)). Later, he conspired with Adonijah against David and Solomon ([1 Kgs 1–2](#)).

1 Samuel 23:1

Keilah was near Adullam ([22:1](#)) at the western edge of Judah, not far from the Philistine border (see [Josh 15:44](#); [Neh 3:17–18](#)).

1 Samuel 23:1–29

Thanks to informants ([23:7](#), [13](#)), Saul was able to stay on David's trail. David also had informants, allowing him to keep one step ahead of Saul ([23:1](#), [9](#), [15](#), [25](#)). David's chief advantage was access to divine guidance and resources ([23:2](#), [4](#), [12](#)), which Saul lacked.

1 Samuel 23:4

David asked the Lord either directly in prayer or by using the ephod (see [23:6, 9](#); [2 Sam 2:1](#); [5:23-24](#)). God's answers were a sign of his blessing and protection (cp. [1 Sam 28:6](#)).

1 Samuel 23:6

the ephod: Saul had slain eighty-five priests who were wearing their ephods ([22:18](#); see study note on [2:18](#)), but the priest who escaped had the high priest's ephod, which contained the Urim and Thummim.

1 Samuel 23:7

God has handed him over to me: To the contrary, see [23:14](#).

1 Samuel 23:14

The strongholds of the wilderness were not man-made structures but natural rock formations that provided refuge. • Ziph was approximately ten miles southeast of Keilah ([23:1](#)).

1 Samuel 23:16

Jonathan . . . encouraged David because he knew that God had chosen David to be king.

1 Samuel 23:17

You are going to be the king. . . I will be next to you (literally *second to you*): Jonathan recognized God's selection of David and renounced any personal ambition to the throne. Jonathan never occupied an official position in David's court but was killed in battle along with his father ([31:2](#)).

1 Samuel 23:18

their solemn pact: See [18:3-4](#); [20:12-17](#). • Jonathan returned home: This was probably the last time David and Jonathan saw each other.

1 Samuel 23:19

Hakilah was a hill in the wilderness region of Ziph ([23:14](#)). • The term Jeshimon is sometimes translated as "wasteland" rather than as a place name. It refers here to a specific wasteland located north of the Dead Sea, on both banks of the Jordan River (see [Num 21:20](#)).

1 Samuel 23:20

Both Keilah ([23:12](#)) and Ziph ([23:14](#); [Ps 54:title](#)) were located in Judah, but neither one provided sanctuary for David, a native of Judah. David's ascension to power was not the result of his own tribe's loyalty but because of the will of God.

1 Samuel 23:24

Maon was about three miles directly south of the wilderness of Ziph ([23:14](#)), approximately ten miles south of Hebron. • The Arabah Valley is a deep rift stretching from above the Sea of Galilee down both sides of the Jordan River to the Dead Sea.

1 Samuel 23:28

the Rock of Escape: It was not uncommon for a place name to commemorate thankfulness to God (e.g., [Gen 22:14](#); [28:19](#); [32:30](#)). The exact rock formation that received this name is unknown.

1 Samuel 23:29

David traveled eastward from the area of Ziph ([23:14](#)) and took refuge in the strongholds of Engedi. These rocky highlands were located on the western shore of the Dead Sea. There was an oasis in this region, making it an ideal place to find water and food.

1 Samuel 24:2

3,000 elite troops: David's force was outnumbered five to one ([23:13](#)).

1 Samuel 24:4

David's men believed, as Saul did, that if the circumstances seem right, the Lord is telling you through those circumstances what to do (cp. [23:7](#)).
 • Perhaps David was able to cut off a piece of the hem of Saul's robe without being apprehended because Saul had taken off the robe and laid it aside, or perhaps he fell asleep in the cave.

1 Samuel 24:5

David's conscience began bothering him because he had dishonored God's anointed king.

1 Samuel 24:6

The Lord's anointed one was not to be violated ([26:9](#), [11](#), [16](#), [23](#); [2 Sam 1:14](#), [16](#); [19:21](#)). David would not harm Saul even though God had anointed him to be the next king ([1 Sam 16:13](#)).

1 Samuel 24:11

my father: Saul was, in fact, David's father-in-law ([18:27](#)). David was demonstrating his respect for the king and recalling a day when their relationship had been much friendlier.

1 Samuel 24:12

May the Lord judge: There was no human authority to adjudicate between Saul and David (cp. [Gen 16:5](#); [31:53](#); [Exod 5:21](#); [Judg 11:27](#)). • Perhaps the Lord will punish you: David rested in God's will rather than trying to force God's hand.

1 Samuel 24:13

The proverb vindicates David and indicts Saul. David refrained from evil deeds, such as killing Saul. Saul, however, repeatedly tried to kill David.

1 Samuel 24:20

I realize that you are surely going to be king: This was Saul's first open admission of the truth (cp. [23:17](#)).

1 Samuel 24:21-22

Now swear to me . . . you will not kill my family: Having descendants was a way that Saul's name would endure among the living. David had already sworn such an oath with Jonathan ([20:14-17](#)).

1 Samuel 25:1

Paran: According to the Masoretic Text, David went to the wilderness of *Paran* after Samuel's death. The Septuagint instead reads *Maon*, which fits better with the following story set in the Maon/Carmel area of Judah. This town in southern Judah (see study note on 1 Samuel 23:24) was probably Nabal's home. The wilderness of Paran itself lay much farther south, in the northern Sinai near Kadesh-barnea, and is elsewhere described as a place of refuge ([Genesis 21:21](#); [1 Kings 11:18](#)).

1 Samuel 25:1-44

This episode about Nabal falls between two accounts in which Saul pursued David and David spared Saul's life. Nabal was similar to Saul.

1 Samuel 25:2

Carmel was a village near Maon, not to be confused with the famous mountain from the Elijah narrative in [1 Kgs 18](#). It was in this village that Saul had erected his monument to celebrate victory over the Amalekites ([1 Sam 15:12](#)).

1 Samuel 25:3

Nabal: See [25:25](#) for insight into the irony of his name. • Unlike her husband, Abigail was a sensible and wise person, as the narrative shows.

1 Samuel 25:8

Sheep-shearing time for herdsmen was like harvest time for farmers, a time of celebration and thankfulness for blessings.

1 Samuel 25:10

son of Jesse: Like Saul ([20:27](#), [31](#); [22:7](#)), Nabal used this designation disrespectfully.

1 Samuel 25:21

he has repaid me evil for good: Cp. [24:17](#).

1 Samuel 25:26

Abigail began and ended ([25:31](#)) her plea by declaring that God had kept you from murdering and taking vengeance: David could have killed Nabal (and Saul), but he didn't.

1 Samuel 25:28

a lasting dynasty: See [2 Sam 7](#). • fighting the Lord's battles: David was known and loved for his victories over Israel's enemies ([1 Sam 18:7](#), [13](#), [16](#)). • have not done wrong: This comment does not indicate that David was sinless, but rather that he was innocent in his quest for the throne (as [25:29–31](#) makes clear).

1 Samuel 25:29

The phrase like stones shot from a sling is a fitting metaphor for David, considering his defeat of Goliath with a sling ([17:32–51](#)).

1 Samuel 25:36

like a king: Nabal was like Saul (see study note on [25:1–44](#)).

1 Samuel 25:37

Nabal was so stunned by the revelation that he had a stroke or a heart attack.

1 Samuel 25:39

Nabal's death was God's punishment for his sin. David could not be accused of vengeful murder. •

David lost no time in asking Abigail to become his wife. She had already shown herself to be a woman of good sense, and she was also beautiful ([25:3](#)).

1 Samuel 25:43

Ahinoam was also the name of Saul's wife ([14:50](#)). If she was the same woman, then David took Saul's widow after his death ([31:1–13](#)), which would make another parallel between Nabal and Saul. However, see [27:3](#); [30:5](#). • This Jezreel was a village in the vicinity of Maon, Ziph, and Carmel in Judah ([Josh 15:55–56](#)) and not the better-known northern city of Jezreel.

1 Samuel 25:44

Saul's motive for giving away Michal to another man was probably political, an attempt to remove any claim David might have on the throne by dissolving David's marriage with a member of the royal family.

1 Samuel 26:1

Men from Ziph had previously volunteered to capture David and hand him over to Saul ([23:19–20](#)). • Hakilah ... Jeshimon is the same geographical location they had mentioned to Saul before ([23:19](#)). David had not moved far, probably because the hilly terrain was dotted with numerous caves, providing many good hiding places.

1 Samuel 26:1–25

This was the last time Saul and David were together. The Ziphites told Saul for the second time where David was hiding (see [23:19–20](#)), and David spared Saul's life a second time as he did in the cave at En-gedi (see ch [24](#)).

1 Samuel 26:3

Saul had come after David again, despite his earlier remorse ([24:17–21](#)). Saul had become incapable of acting rationally or speaking truthfully.

1 Samuel 26:5

Abner son of Ner: See study note on 20:25.

1 Samuel 26:6

This is the only reference to Ahimelech the Hittite.
 • Zeruiah was David's sister ([1 Chr 2:16](#)), so Abishai was David's nephew. The sons of Zeruiah (Abishai, Joab, and Asahel) were three of David's most faithful followers (e.g., [2 Sam 2:18](#)), but they sometimes caused David difficulty (see [2 Sam 3:39; 16:10; 19:22](#)).

1 Samuel 26:8

God has surely handed your enemy over to you: Cp. [24:4](#).

1 Samuel 26:9

the Lord's anointed: See study note on 24:6.

1 Samuel 26:10

David was confident that God would judge between him and Saul just as he had done between him and Nabal (see [25:38](#)). Saul did die . . . in battle against the Philistines ([31:6](#)).

1 Samuel 26:14

Abner: See study note on 20:25.

1 Samuel 26:16

deserve to die: Death was the punishment for dereliction of duty.

1 Samuel 26:17

Is that you, my son David? Cp. [24:16](#).

1 Samuel 26:19

If the Lord has stirred you up against me: David was perplexed by Saul's behavior and concerned with the possibility of unintentional sin on his part.
 • a human scheme: Possibly a reference to Doeg ([22:9–10](#)).
 • worship pagan gods: The sentiment parallels [Ps 137:4](#). Anyone who was exiled from the holy land was unable to worship the Lord by participating in sacrifice at the central sanctuary.

1 Samuel 26:20

a single flea: Cp. [24:14](#).

1 Samuel 26:21

I have sinned: Saul had seen the error of his ways once before ([24:16–19](#)). David had no good reason to trust him this time (see [27:1](#)).
 • I have been a fool: This Hebrew term (sakal, "play the fool," see also [13:13](#)) is different from the word meaning "fool" (nabal) used in ch [25](#). However, the two words have parallel meanings. Saul and Nabal are parallel figures.

1 Samuel 26:23

David did not harm Saul ([24:6; 26:9](#)) because Saul was the Lord's anointed one (see study note on 24:6).

1 Samuel 26:24

may the Lord value my life, even as I have valued yours: David could not count on Saul to reciprocate. Thus, his fate was in God's hands.

1 Samuel 26:25

Saul returned home, and this may have been David's last personal encounter with him.

1 Samuel 27:1–12

David fled to the Philistines to get away from Saul for good. Rather than killing Saul, David chose the dangerous life of a fugitive.

1 Samuel 27:2

This was David's second sojourn with Achish, the Philistine king (see [21:10-15](#)). On both occasions, David lied to him (see [27:10](#)).

1 Samuel 27:6

Ziklag was about twenty-two miles southwest of Gath. • still belongs to the kings of Judah: This note was written between Solomon's death (931 BC) and the start of the Babylonian exile (586 BC).

1 Samuel 27:8

Geshurites . . . Girzites . . . Amalekites: These groups, who lived on the edges of the southern desert, had been troublesome to both Philistines and Israelites. (On the Amalekites, see [14:48](#); ch [15](#); on the Geshurites, see [Josh 13:2, 13](#); [2 Sam 3:3](#).) • Shur was somewhere east of Egypt ([1 Sam 15:7](#); [Gen 16:7](#); [20:1](#); [25:18](#)).

1 Samuel 27:9

David did not leave one person alive: At least some of these people were among those whom God had commanded Israel to destroy (see [15:3](#); [28:18](#); [Deut 25:17-19](#); [Josh 13:13](#)).

1 Samuel 27:10

David misled Achish by claiming his attacks were against his own people of Judah and two other related groups. The text does not commend David for lying to the foreign king, but neither does it condemn him. • The Jerahmeelites were a Semitic tribe in southern Judah ([1 Chr 2:9, 25-27, 33, 42](#)). • Kenites: Moses' father-in-law was a Kenite ([Judg 1:16](#); [4:11](#); see also study note on 1 Sam 15:6).

1 Samuel 28:1

another war: Hostilities between Israel and the Philistines were now routine. In exchange for providing refuge, Achish expected David's military involvement and cooperation.

1 Samuel 28:3

banned from the land: Saul had either expelled or killed most mediums, or he had merely outlawed the practice of necromancy (see study note on 28:9).

1 Samuel 28:3-14

Saul consulted the dead, a practice forbidden by God's law (see [Lev 20:27](#); [Deut 18:9-11](#)).

1 Samuel 28:4

Shunem, a border town in the territory of Issachar ([Josh 19:18](#)), overlooked the valley of Jezreel. • Mount Gilboa is at the east end of the valley of Jezreel. The mountain took its name from a nearby village.

1 Samuel 28:6

refused to answer: Earlier, Saul had consulted the Lord by sacred lots with mixed results ([14:36-42](#)). God's refusal to speak was a sign of his judgment ([14:37](#); [Lam 2:9](#); [Ezek 7:26](#); [Amos 8:11-12](#); [Mic 3:6-7](#)).

1 Samuel 28:7

Excluded from God's counsel, Saul resorted to illegitimate methods for finding God's will. Saul had earlier prohibited the occult practice that he now engaged in himself ([28:3](#)). • Endor was on the boundary between Israel and Philistia; the area near Israel's border was probably a safer location for a banned practice.

1 Samuel 28:9

outlawed: Literally *cut off*, suggesting that Saul might have had most of the mediums executed.

1 Samuel 28:12

It is not clear why seeing Samuel caused the woman to recognize Saul.

1 Samuel 28:13

Saul asked the medium to describe what she saw that caused her to scream. She described a divine being, a god (Hebrew *'elohim*) coming up. Perhaps she observed a human figure with a godlike or angelic appearance, or her use of the term *god* might reflect a pagan belief that a person becomes *a god*—a spirit possessing supernatural abilities—after death.

1 Samuel 28:15

God has left me: The same Hebrew term is used in [16:14](#) and [Judg 16:20](#). • won't reply by prophets or dreams: Cp. [1 Sam 28:6](#).

1 Samuel 28:16

Saul's enemy was not David but the Lord himself.

1 Samuel 28:17

torn the kingdom from you: See [15:28](#).

1 Samuel 28:18

you refused: Samuel's message to Saul had not changed (cp. [15:19](#)).

1 Samuel 28:19

here with me: In *Sheol*, the abode of the dead (cp. [2:6](#), "the grave"; see also [Num 16:30–33](#); [Job 17:1–16](#); [Ps 49:11](#); [Rev 1:18](#)).

1 Samuel 28:24

fattening a calf . . . dough . . . bread: This meal was a major undertaking, a model of hospitality (cp. [Gen 18:5–7](#)). This meal the medium shared with Saul

recalls the fine meal Samuel had shared with Saul ([1 Sam 9:22–24](#)) before he anointed Saul as king. That meal with God's prophet marked the beginning of Saul's kingship. This meal with a condemned spiritist came shortly before his death.

1 Samuel 29:1

Aphek was the site of an earlier confrontation between Israel and the Philistines ([4:1](#)). • Jezreel was about forty miles northeast of Aphek.

1 Samuel 29:1–11

David was spared by divine providence from actually fighting against his own people.

1 Samuel 29:3

servant of King Saul: To Achish, David was a valued defector. The other Philistine rulers suspected that David was a plant, planning to mount an attack from within the Philistine defenses. • never found a single fault: This was the first of three times that Achish defended David (see also [29:6, 9](#)). Yet David had been deceiving Achish the whole time (see [27:1–12](#)).

1 Samuel 29:4

handing our heads over: The commanders' fears were justified (cp. [17:51](#); [18:27](#)).

1 Samuel 29:5

This jingle referred to slain Philistines ([18:7](#)). It is remarkable that David could find refuge in their midst.

1 Samuel 29:6

by the Lord: Achish used the unique name of Israel's God to prove his own sincerity. • a trustworthy ally: This assertion was not completely true, though Achish did not realize it ([27:8–12](#)).

1 Samuel 30:1

Ziklag: See study note on 27:6. • Perhaps the Amalekites were retaliating for David's raids against them ([27:8](#)).

1 Samuel 30:2

There were no fighting men left in Ziklag to protect the women and children. The Amalekites had a reputation for preying on the weak and vulnerable (see [Deut 25:17-18](#)). • without killing anyone: The Amalekites were not being compassionate; women and children were more useful alive than dead.

1 Samuel 30:5

Ahinoam: See study note on 25:43. • Abigail: See [25:3-42](#).

1 Samuel 30:6

in great danger: Saul had used the same expression about himself: When "in deep trouble" ([28:15](#)), Saul turned to necromancy, with disastrous results. David, by contrast, found strength and success in the Lord his God.

1 Samuel 30:7

the ephod: See study notes on 2:18; 23:6.

1 Samuel 30:8

Unlike Saul ([28:6](#)), David inquired of the Lord successfully (see [23:9-12](#); [2 Sam 2:1](#); [5:19](#), [23](#)).

1 Samuel 30:9

Besor was a large brook in Philistine territory that emptied into the Mediterranean southwest of Gaza.

1 Samuel 30:10

too exhausted: David's men had traveled for three days ([30:1](#)) and were now in hot pursuit of the

Amalekites without having rested. David did not upbraid them or drive them on mercilessly. See [30:23-25](#).

1 Samuel 30:11-12

David had once received bread when he was famished ([21:3-7](#)). He and his men helped this Egyptian man before they even knew his identity or his ability to help their cause.

1 Samuel 30:13

because I was sick: Only healthy and vigorous slaves were valuable to the Amalekites; the rest were expendable.

1 Samuel 30:14

The land of Caleb was in the wilderness of Judah, south of Hebron (see [Josh 14:6-15](#)).

1 Samuel 30:17

The total number of Amalekite raiders must have been quite large if 400 young men escaped.

1 Samuel 30:21

greeted them joyfully: David did not reprimand them for not participating in the battle.

1 Samuel 30:21-31

David generously divided the spoils among those who participated in the battle and those who were too exhausted to take part.

1 Samuel 30:22

tell them to be gone: This heartless group wanted to drive away the nonparticipants with no reward.

1 Samuel 30:23

what the Lord has given: Some of David's men ascribed success to their own military prowess; David attributed victory to God and gave him the glory.

1 Samuel 30:24

share and share alike: Cp. [Num 31:25-47](#), where Moses divided the plunder of war between those who fought and the rest of the people.

1 Samuel 30:26

elders of Judah . . . his friends: David extended his generosity to influential people throughout his own tribal area, possibly to secure their support for him as king.

1 Samuel 30:27-30

The places mentioned here were all in southern Judah. David eventually emerged from this territory as king (see [2 Sam 2:1-4](#)).

1 Samuel 30:31

From Hebron, David reigned as king over Judah for 7½ years ([2 Sam 2:1-7](#); [5:5](#)).

1 Samuel 31:1

The Israelites fled southeast from the Jezreel Valley ([29:1](#)) to higher and hillier ground. With their chariots, the Philistines had the advantage in the more level valley. • Mount Gilboa is southwest of the Sea of Galilee, far from the territory of the Philistines.

1 Samuel 31:1-13

While David was in the south successfully fighting the Amalekites (ch [30](#)), Saul was in the north unsuccessfully fighting the Philistines.

1 Samuel 31:2

Jonathan . . . Malkishua: See [14:49](#). This is the first mention of Saul's son Abinadab (cp. [1 Chr 8:33; 9:39](#)).

1 Samuel 31:4

David had once held the position of armor bearer ([16:21](#)). • kill me: This is one of many parallels between the death of Abimelech in the time of the judges ([Judg 9](#)) and Saul, Israel's first national king (cp. [Judg 9:54](#)).

1 Samuel 31:8

The victorious army would strip the dead to search for anything valuable (such as clothing, weapons, or jewelry) on the corpses.

1 Samuel 31:9

In the ancient world, the death of an enemy king was good news, for it meant that the enemy's god had been defeated. However, little did the Philistines know that their victory would be short-lived and hollow. David, the Lord's true anointed king, would soon come to power and pay back the Philistines mightily. Far from defeating Israel's God, the Philistines were simply fulfilling his purpose.

1 Samuel 31:10

the Ashtoreths: See [7:3](#). • fastened his body: This practice further degraded the executed person by depriving him of proper burial. It also served as a deterrent to other potential enemies (see also [Gen 40:19](#); [Deut 21:21-22](#); [Josh 10:26](#); [Esth 9:6-14](#)). • Beth-shan was a short distance east of Mount Gilboa.

1 Samuel 31:11

The people of Jabesh-gilead were returning the favor Saul had done for them when he saved them from the Ammonites and their king Nahash ([11:1-13](#)). Jabesh-gilead was about twelve miles southeast of Beth-shan and across the Jordan River.

1 Samuel 31:12

burned the bodies: Cremation was rare. It is possible the bodies were burned because decomposition had already set in.

1 Samuel 31:13

bones . . . Jabesh: This was not the final resting place of Saul's remains (see [2 Sam 21:12-14](#)). • The ending of 1 Samuel brings Israel's history back to the situation at the end of Judges, when "Israel had no king." Once again, the Philistines were in control. David had God's anointing but no crown. He had wives but no sons. His affiliation with the hated Philistines might jeopardize his standing among his own people. David's future path would be challenging, but God was clearly with him.